

Cross-linguistic realization of Transitivity in proverbial structures: a thematic view

Soroor Azam Karamloo, Autonomous University of Madrid

mskaramloo@yahoo.com

Abstract

This study compares 774 equivalent proverbs in English, Persian, and Spanish using Halliday's (1994) Systemic Functional Grammar (SFG), focusing on the experiential and textual metafunctions. I selected 258 proverbs from each language using monolingual dictionaries and analyzed their clause structures in terms of process, participant, and circumstance along the Theme and Rheme of the clauses. Although researchers have applied SFG to comparative linguistics, they have not explored proverbs across these three languages. I hypothesize that equivalent proverbs share semantic and syntactic features despite cultural and structural differences. The analysis reveals that although similar trend is followed across the three corpora, English and Persian prove to be more similar syntactically and semantically in terms of participant types both in the Theme and Rheme.

Keywords: proverb analysis . Systemic Functional Grammar . syntax-semantic interface . Transitivity . Theme . English . Persian . Spanish

Abbreviation

1	first person
2	second person
3	third person
DOM ¹	direct object marker
F	female
FUT	future
IMP	imperative
INF	infinitive

¹ DOM stands for direct object marker. In Persian an object NP is generally followed by a direct object marker (DOM) *raa*.

M	masculine
N	neuter
NEG	negative
O	object
PL	plural
POSS	possessive
PRS	present
PST	past
PTCP	participle
Q	question mark
REFL	reflexive
S	subject
SBJV	subjunctive mood
SG	singular

1. Introduction

Paremiology refers to the systematic examination of the characteristics, structures, and roles of proverbs, typically pursued to facilitate both interlingual and intralingual analyses. This discipline is intrinsically linked to paremiography—the practice of compiling proverbs—as any meaningful paremiological inquiry necessitates access to collections previously assembled by paremiographers. In many cases, including the present investigation, the roles of paremiographer and paremiologist may converge, with the researcher drawing upon a range of monolingual proverb dictionaries in Persian, English, and Spanish to identify corresponding expressions. This study has prioritized the consultation of the most authoritative and frequently referenced sources in the field.

This investigation undertakes a comparative analysis of Persian proverbs and their counterparts in English and Spanish through the lens of two of the three metafunctions outlined in Systemic Functional Linguistics (SFL) / Systemic Functional Grammar (SFG) i.e., experiential and textual metafunctions. This theoretical framework, initially introduced by M. A. K. Halliday and subsequently refined in collaboration with scholars such as Suzanne Eggins, Ruqaiya Hasan, James Robert Martin, and Christian M. I. M. Matthiessen, among others, provides a comprehensive model for examining language (Halliday, 1967, 1968, 1975, 1978, 1985, 1994; Halliday & Hasan, 1976; Halliday & Matthiessen, 2004; Hasan, 1984, 1985; Eggins, 2004; Martin, 1992; Matthiessen, 1995, 2009). Within this framework, three analytical systems—TRANSITIVITY, MOOD, and THEME—are employed to investigate the metafunctions that concurrently shape all linguistic utterances, offering insights into their semantic, pragmatic, and syntactic dimensions. Notably, the present study confines its analysis to the TRANSITIVITY and THEME systems.

The limited body of research addressing the analysis of proverbs within the framework of Systemic Functional Grammar (SFG), coupled with the absence of studies focusing specifically on proverbs from three Indo-European languages—English, Persian, and Spanish—has prompted an investigation into their shared structural and semantic characteristics. Although a handful of prior studies have undertaken grammatical comparisons using the SFG model—such as those by McCabe (1999), Mohammadi & Nabifar (2012), Rodríguez Arancón (2013), Dabbagh & Noshadi (2015), Akabuike (2020), Emodi (2021), and Emodi & Okeke (2022)—the current research seeks to address a notable gap in sampling. This gap pertains both to the genre of the linguistic data, namely proverbs, and to the inclusion of multiple languages within a single comparative framework. For instance, McCabe’s analysis involved 1,496 clauses extracted from historical textbooks in English and Spanish.

The overarching objective of this study is to examine the structural and semantic aspects of proverbs in Persian, English, and Spanish, with the aim of identifying common linguistic features. To this end, the research conducts a trilingual comparison of 774 equivalent proverbs, employing Systemic Functional Grammar (SFG) as the analytical model. This framework enables a detailed syntactic and semantic examination of the data through the TRANSITIVITY and THEME systems, thereby facilitating clause-level analysis.

In pursuit of this goal, this study outlines two principal objectives: (1) assessing the ratio of the distribution of the process, participant, and circumstance types in the Theme and the Rheme of the proverbs in the three languages; and (2) to compare the resulting data across the three languages under investigation. Upon completion of these tasks, the study will proceed to evaluate its hypotheses.

This study is based on two hypotheses concerning the relationship between 3 languages, that are Persian, English and Spanish. The first hypothesis concerns the common grammatical properties of equivalent proverbs in the three languages under investigation in this research, hence it examines the manifestation of the elements in the TRANSITIVITY system, such as process, participant, and circumstance in the equivalent proverbs along the Theme and Rheme of the clause based on THEME system. The second hypothesis investigates whether there are any cross-linguistic similarities or differences among the proverbs in the three languages. These hypotheses are as follows:

H1. All languages have resources for construing our experience of the world around us (ideational metafunction), which is reflected in the system of TRANSITIVITY through functional configurations consisting of a combination of processes, participants, and circumstances, so proverbs used in different languages to describe the same experience can be assumed to refer to similar situations.

H2. Given that proverbs are concise, traditional expressions of advice or perceived truths grounded in common experience, equivalent proverbs across languages may share semantic properties despite cultural and structural variation. Since language represents experience through the Transitivity system—one of the core components of the experiential metafunction—analyzing equivalent proverbs in terms of their process types, participants, and circumstances can reveal meaningful cross-linguistic similarities and differences in how experience is encoded

In other words, the objective of this study is to ascertain whether the proverbs used in pragmatically equivalent situations describe the same kind of experience using similar clause constituents. In order to achieve the objectives of the study, two specific research questions (RQs) were considered:

RQ1. Is the information contained in a sentence organized in a similar manner in equivalent proverbs in different languages?

RQ2. Does an analysis of the grammatical properties of equivalent proverbs in different languages show similarities and differences among those languages?

To initiate the analysis presented in this study, it is both appropriate and necessary to examine a key grammatical feature shared by the three languages under consideration—their canonical word order—given its potential impact on the subsequent linguistic investigation. Word order typology, a subfield of language typology, concerns itself with the arrangement of clausal elements across the world's languages (Greenberg 1963; Comrie 1989). Six principal word order patterns are recognized (SOV, SVO, VSO, VOS, OVS, and OSV), with SOV, SVO, and VSO being the most prevalent

سارا کتابش را خواند.

- سارا خواند کتابش را.

- English, like Persian, is classified as an analytic language; however, its syntactic structure is notably more rigid, with Subject-Verb-Object (SVO) serving as its canonical word order. Deviations from this pattern—aside from specific constructions involving subject-verb inversion—typically result in a change in sentence meaning. For instance, the sentences “The teacher praised the student” and “The student praised the teacher” convey entirely distinct propositions.

Spanish, while exhibiting analytic tendencies, is comparatively more synthetic than both Persian and English, relying more heavily on inflectional morphology to encode grammatical relationships such as tense, mood, person, number, and gender. Consequently, although SVO is the most commonly observed word order in Spanish, the language allows for considerable flexibility in the arrangement of clausal constituents. This syntactic variability enables the same semantic content to be expressed through multiple structural configurations, each carrying unique discourse-pragmatic implications. For

² In Persian an object NP is generally followed by a direct object marker (DOM) *raa*.

example, the sentence *El professor elogió al estudiante* (“The teacher praised the student”) may be reformulated as *Al estudiante lo elogió el professor*, *Al estudiante el professor lo elogió*, *Elogió el professor al estudiante*, or *Elogió al estudiante el professor*, all of which preserve the core meaning while differing in emphasis and information structure.

The organization of the paper is as follows: Section 2 describes the methodological framework, including the procedures for data collection, the materials and instruments employed, and the analytical strategy. Section 3 reports the findings, supported by tables and figures along with interpretative remarks. Section 4 examines the results in the context of the research questions. Finally, Section 5 summarizes the study’s conclusions, emphasizing its significance and proposing avenues for subsequent investigation.

2. Methodology

This research conducts a cross-linguistic examination of proverbs in Persian, English, and Spanish, applying the TRANSITIVITY and THEME frameworks within the scope of Systemic Functional Grammar (SFG), as articulated by Halliday (1985, 1994, 2004, 2014) and subsequent scholars. The core dataset consists of proverbs drawn from reputable sources, including monolingual dictionaries specific to each language and multilingual online compilations. Adopting a mixed-methods approach, the study incorporates both quantitative and qualitative analyses. Semantic interpretation is guided by the TRANSITIVITY system, aligned with the ideational metafunction of SFG, while syntactic structure is examined through the THEME system, corresponding to the textual metafunction. The choice of languages reflects the researcher’s native command of Persian and high-level proficiency in English and Spanish. The selected corpus features widely acknowledged proverbs that promote wisdom, foster intellectual development, reinforce ethical values, and warn against ignorance—capturing culturally resonant themes.

The data collection process was conducted sequentially, beginning with Persian, followed by English, and concluding with Spanish. For the Persian corpus, the primary source consulted was *Amsaal o Hekam* by Ali Akbar Dehkhoda (1984), supplemented by *Qand o Namak* by Jafar Shahri (2021), along with additional references such as *Farhang Bozorg Zabolmasalha-ye Farsi* by Hasan Zou Alfaghari (2009) and *Majma ol Amsaal* by Mohammad Ali Hableroudi (1965). The English dataset focused exclusively on proverbs from the United States and the United Kingdom, drawing primarily from *Early American Proverbs and Proverbial Phrases* by Bartlett Jere Whiting (1977), *A Dictionary of American Proverbs* edited

by Wolfgang Mieder et al. (1992), *Dictionary of Authentic American Proverbs* by Mieder (2021), *Oxford Dictionary of Proverbs* by Simpson and Speake (2002), and *The Wordsworth Dictionary of Proverbs* by Apperson (1993). The Spanish corpus was compiled using esteemed sources such as *Diccionario de Refranes, Adagios, Modismos, Locuciones y Frases Proverbiales de la Lengua Española* by Jose María Sbarbi y Osuna (1922), *Vocabulario de Refranes y Frases Proverbiales* by Gonzalo Correas (1924), and the online repository *El Refranero Multilingüe*, developed by the Cervantes Institute and launched by Julia Sevilla Muñoz and María Teresa Zurdo Ruiz-Ayúcar in 2009. In total, 774 proverbs were collected—258 from each language—all consisting of single T-unit³ clauses.

The collected proverbs were analysed in MS Word using the TRANSITIVITY and THEME systems of SFG, as shown in Tables 1–3. The analysis was stored in three separate files, one per language. TRANSITIVITY revealed semantic and syntactic features by breaking each proverb into participant(s), process, and circumstance(s), with the process verb identified first. THEME analysis distinguished Theme from Rheme, requiring an ideational element within the Theme. Examples appear in Tables 1–3 (Appendices A–C supplied in Online Resource).

System	A dog barks against the moon.		
	A dog	barks	against the moon
TRANSITIVITY	Actor	Process: Material	Circumstance
	Topical Theme		
THEME	Theme	Rheme	

Table 1 An example of an analysis of an English proverb based on the TRANSITIVITY system

System	آب رفته به جوی نمی آید باز.			
	Aabe rafteh be joy nayaayad baaz. ‘Spilt water does not return to the stream.’			
	Aabe rafteh	be juy	nemiaayad	baaz
	Water spilt	to the stream	does not	return
TRANSITIVITY	Actor	Circumstance: Location	Process: Material	
	Topical Theme			
THEME	Theme	Rheme		

Table 2 An example of an analysis of a Persian proverb based on the TRANSITIVITY system

System	De la abundancia del corazón habla la boca. ‘The mouth speaks of the fullness of the heart’		
	De la abundancia del corazón	habla	la boca
TRANSITIVITY	Verbiage	Process: Verbal	Sayer
	Topical Theme		
THEME	Theme	Rheme	

Table 3 An example of an analysis of a Spanish proverb based on the TRANSITIVITY system

³ A T-unit is any independent or main clause with all its subordinate clauses embedded in it (Hunt 1977).

The ideational metafunction comprises experiential and logical components. The experiential aspect, realized through the TRANSITIVITY system, uses process, participant, and circumstance to express experience. Each process involves at least one participant—either causing or affected by it—and occurs within a circumstance that supports but does not alter the clause's core meaning if removed.

The processes are the central element of a clause, as they represent actions, thoughts, and states, thereby facilitating the understanding of our real-world experience. The main types of process in the TRANSITIVITY system are: material (if it deals with outer experience involving actions and events), mental (if it deals with inner experiences expressing feeling or state of mind), relational (if it relates a part of an experience to another), behavioural (if it refers to the display of psychological and physiological states), verbal (if it involves saying or narration), and existential (if it is concerned with existence).

The participants are the entities involved in the processes, and their roles vary depending on the type of process. The main participant roles include: Actor, Goal, Recipient, and Client (in material processes); Sensor and Phenomenon (in mental processes); Carrier, Attribute, Identified, and Identifier (in relational processes); Sayer, Receiver, and Verbiage (in verbal processes); Behaver (in behavioural processes); and Existent (in existential processes).

Circumstances provide additional information about the process in a clause by specifying contextual details and, unlike participants, which are directly involved in the process, circumstances simply function as optional elements that enhance meaning. The main types of circumstances include: extent (distance, duration), location (space or time), manner (means or quality), cause (reason, purpose), contingency, accompaniment, matter, angle, and role. The circumstances, which are referred to as adjuncts in traditional grammar, are generally realized through adverbial phrases, prepositional phrases, or noun phrases.

The textual metafunction organizes language for effective communication by structuring information to ensure coherence and cohesion. Halliday (1985) identifies thematic and information structures, along with cohesion mechanisms, as key components. Thematic structure arranges experiential content to convey meaning, viewing each clause as a message composed of a Theme (the attention-drawing starting point) and a Rheme (the following element).

Due to the principle of thematic structures (Halliday & Matthiessen, 2014: 105), which states that, in a clause, the Theme should only include one of the elements of the TRANSITIVITY system – that is a participant, a process, or a circumstance – and should be considered a topical (or experiential or ideational) Theme, the Theme is therefore identified on the basis of the presence of one of these elements, whether a participant, a process, or a circumstance.

As is shown in Tables 1, 2 and 3, the data obtained from the analysis of proverbs in Spanish, English, and Persian were compared through a trilingual examination to identify similarities and differences based on the variables of the TRANSITIVITY system (participant, process, circumstance) as well as those of the THEME system (Theme and Rheme). This information helps us to answer the first and the second research questions (RQ1 & RQ2):

RQ1: Is the information contained in a sentence organized in a similar manner in equivalent proverbs in different languages?

RQ2: Does an analysis of the grammatical properties of equivalent proverbs in different languages show the similarities and differences between those languages?

To address RQ1, process types in each proverb were recorded and organized in an Excel chart with eleven rows and three language columns. Five rows represented material, mental, verbal, behavioural, and existential processes; the remaining six covered relational processes—attributive and identifying—classified as intensive, possessive, or circumstantial. Percentages and trilingual means were calculated. Participant types were charted in 21 rows, and circumstance types in eight, each with three language columns and corresponding calculations. Graphs were then created to visualize the ratio of TRANSITIVITY elements (participant, process, circumstance) per language and in trilingual comparison across Theme and Rheme. RQ2 was addressed by comparing grammatical properties across languages, focusing on Theme–Rheme distinctions.

The final analysis involved a Chi-Square test to determine whether significant relationships existed between the proverbs in three languages and the TRANSITIVITY variables—process, participant, and circumstance—within Theme and Rheme. This test, commonly used for comparing multiple variables, was applied to assess the research hypotheses. All analyses were conducted in Excel.

Data collection and analysis challenges are common in scientific research. A key issue in this study was proverbs with multiple T-units, which hindered equivalent analysis and reduced the dataset from 1,300 to 774. Another challenge involved proverbial phrases lacking a process, essential for clause-based analysis. Rather than excluding them, missing elements—typically the process—were added. This approach was also applied to minor clauses missing one or more constituents. Examples of these adjusted proverbs follow.

(3) Out of sight, out of mind.

In this example, which means that when you don't see someone or something for a while, you tend to forget about them or stop thinking about them, what is missing is a verb. For this reason, the be verb 'is' was inserted into its structure to make it

possible for the clause to have a verb, in this case, a to be verb. As a result of this, the clause changed into ‘Out of sight (is) out of mind’. Then, the relevant participants of this clause are the two nominal groups ‘out of sight’ and ‘out of mind’, respectively, among which, the first one is the Theme of the clause.

(4) Rob Peter to pay Paul.

In this example, which means to take resources (usually money) from one area to cover debt or expense in another, without actually solving the overall problem, as it is a proverbial expression, there is no subject. Consequently, the clause was transformed into ‘One robs Peter to pay Paul’ by introducing the pronominal subject ‘one’ as the Theme and making the verb finite (‘robs’) in order to enable the analysis of this instance of declarative mood.

(5) Better late than never.

In this example, which means it is preferable to do something late than never, three constituents are missing: a dummy subject ‘it’, the copula ‘is’, and the particle of infinitive ‘to’ accompanying the auxiliary verb ‘be’. By adding the missing elements, the clause changes into a predicated theme like ‘It is better to be late than never’. In this case, ‘It’ is the subject and the Theme, the verb ‘is’ functions as the to be verb. The mood of this clause is declarative.

3. Results

This section presents a comparative analysis of proverbs in three languages using two systems from Halliday’s Systemic Functional Grammar: TRANSITIVITY and THEME. TRANSITIVITY, part of the experiential metafunction, examines processes, participants, and circumstances, while THEME structures these elements within clauses. Together, they support the semantic and syntactic comparison of the proverbs.

3.1 Process

In SFG, a process denotes the event expressed by a clause’s verb, classified into six types: material, mental, relational, behavioural, verbal, and existential. Relational processes are further divided into attributive and identifying, each with intensive, possessive, and circumstantial categories—yielding 11 types overall. Their distribution across English, Persian, and Spanish corpora is discussed below, with each proverb’s process in Theme and Rheme italicized and labeled in parentheses.

3.1.1 English

The analysis of the English proverbs corpus in this study revealed a diverse range of process types, with a higher concentration occurring in the Rheme than in the Theme. While all six process types – material, relational, mental, verbal, behavioural, and existential – were identified in the Rheme, only material and behavioural processes were found in the Theme. An example of each process type occurring in both the Theme and the Rheme is presented below for illustration:

- (6) Don't *play* with edged tools. (Material process in Theme)
- (7) Don't *cry* over spilt milk. (Behavioural process in Theme)
- (8) A live coward *is* better than a dead hero. (Relational intensive attributive in Rheme)
- (9) A dog *barks* against the moon. (Material process in Rheme)
- (10) Hunger never *saw* bad bread. (Mental process in Rheme)
- (11) There *is* no little enemy. (Existential process in Rheme)
- (12) Distrust *is* the mother of security. (Relational intensive identifying in Rheme)
- (13) Other times *have* other manners. (Relational possessive attributive in Rheme)
- (14) A sound mind *is* in a sound body. (Relational circumstantial attributive in Rheme)
- (15) Your enemies *tell* you your faults. (Verbal process in Rheme)
- (16) The darkest hour *is* just before the day. (Relational circumstantial identifying in Rheme)
- (17) As you make your bed, you must *lie* on it. (Behavioural process in Rheme)
- (18) One's house *is* one's castle. (Relational possessive identifying in Rheme)

The results of the analysis of process types in the Theme and the Rheme in English proverbs (Figure 1) showed that only two appeared in the Theme: material (N = 11) and behavioural (N = 2). In the analysis for Rheme, the results showed relational intensive attributive (N = 87), and material (N = 84) followed equally by mental and existential (N = 15), and relational intensive identifying (N = 14) as the most frequent processes in the English corpus. This order was followed equally by relational possessive attributive and relational circumstantial attributive (N = 9) followed by verbal (N = 8), and then relational circumstantial identifying (N = 2). However, there were two processes that appeared only once (N = 1) in the Rheme of the clauses; these were relational possessive identifying and behavioural.

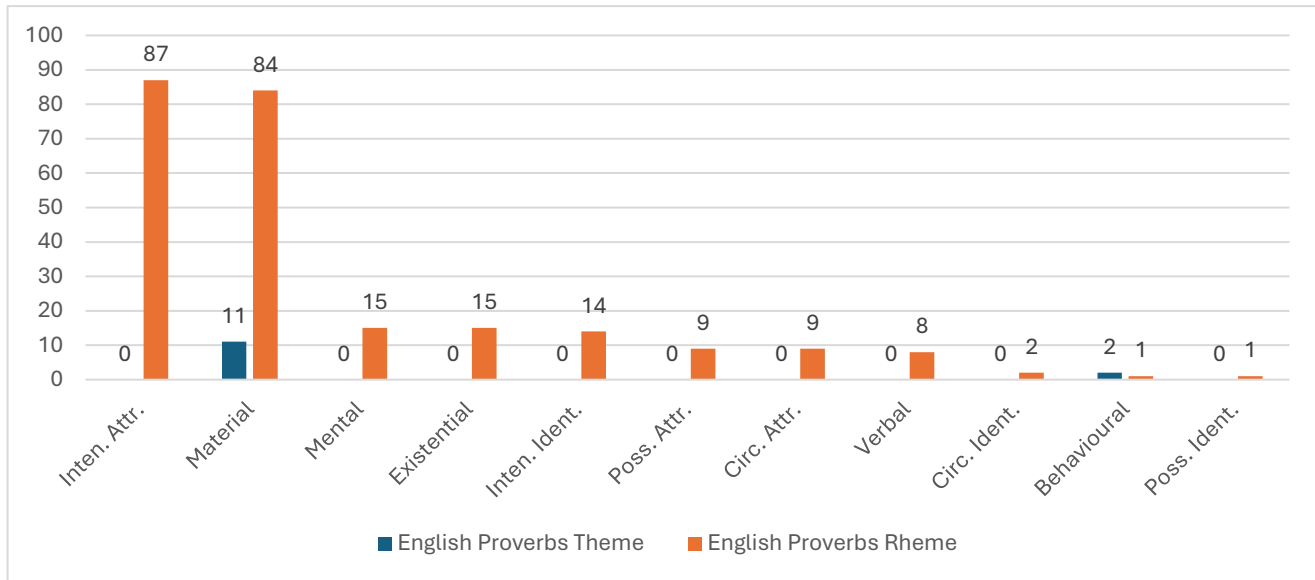


Fig. 1 Frequency of the process types in Theme and Rheme in the English proverbs

The results of relative frequency showed (Table 4) the only two process types to appear in the Theme of the English corpus were material (84.6%) and behavioural (15.3%). The order of process types found in the Rheme of this corpus reveals that relational intensive attributive processes (35.5%) and material processes (34.2%) were the most frequently occurring, followed equally by mental and existential processes (6.1%), and subsequently by relational intensive identifying processes (5.7%). This order was followed equally by relational possessive attributive and relational circumstantial attributive (3.6%), verbal (3.2%), and relational circumstantial identifying (0.8%). There were two processes that appeared only once (0.4%): behavioural and relational possessive identifying. Relational possessive identifying and behavioural only appeared in this corpus once (0.4%).

English Proverbs					
Process Types	Theme	Percentage	Process Types	Rheme	Percentage
Material	11	84.6%	Intensive attributive	87	35.5%
Behavioural	2	15.3%	Material	84	34.2%
Verbal	0	0%	Mental	15	6.1%
Mental	0	0%	Existential	15	6.1%
Existential	0	0%	Intensive identifying	14	5.7%
Intensive Identifying	0	0%	Possessive attributive	9	3.6%
Intensive Attributive	0	0%	Circumstantial attributive	9	3.6%
Possessive Identifying	0	0%	Verbal	8	3.2%
Possessive Attributive	0	0%	Circumstantial identifying	2	0.8%
Circumstantial Attributive	0	0%	Behavioural	1	0.4%
Circumstantial Identifying	0	0%	Possessive identifying	1	0.4%
Total	13	100%	Total	245	100.0%

Table 4 Relative frequency of the process types in Theme and Rheme in the English proverb

3.1.2 Persian

The analysis of the Persian corpus revealed that no process was found in the Theme position. This absence is attributed to the tendency of Persian to place the verb in clause-final position, which inherently restricts the occurrence of processes in thematic positions within the clause structure. However, the analysis of Rheme analysis brought up a variety of processes.

The following are some examples of these processes in the Rheme:

آب در هاون می‌کوبد.

(19) Aab dar haavan mikoobad.

water in mortar pound.PRS.3SG.S

‘He pounds water in a mortar.’ (Lit. ‘Water in mortar (he) pounds.’) (Material)

آزمند همیشه نیازمند است.

(20) Aazmand hamisheh niyaazmand ast.

greedy always needy be.PRS.3SG.S

‘A greedy person is always needy.’ (Lit. ‘Greedy always needy is.’) (Relational intensive attributive)

احتیاط شرط عقل است.

- (21) Ehtiyaat sharte aghl ast.
cautiousness condition.of wisdom be.PRS.3SG.S

‘Cautiousness is the condition of wisdom.’ (Lit. ‘Cautiousness condition of wisdom is.’) (Relational intensive identifying)

کافر همه را به کیش خود پندارد.

- (22) Kaafar hame raa be kische khod pendaarad.
atheist all DOM to religion.of 3SG.S.REFL think.PRS.3SG.S

‘An atheist thinks everyone is an atheist.’ (Lit. ‘Atheist all to his religion thinks.’) (Mental)

بادمجان بم آفت ندارد.

- (23) Bademjaane Bam⁴ aafat nadaarad.
eggplant.of Bam plague NEG.have.PRS.3SG.S

‘Eggplants of Bam don’t have the plague.’ (Lit. ‘Eggplant of Bam plague has not.’) (Relational possessive attributive)

عقل سالم در بدن سالم است.

- (24) Aghle saalem dar badane saalem ast.
mind healthy in body healthy be.PRS.3SG.S

‘A sound mind is in a healthy body.’ (Lit. ‘Mind sound in a body healthy is.’) (Relational circumstantial attributive)

خودکرده را تدبیر نیست.

- (25) Khodkardeh raa tadbir nist.
culpable DOM remedy NEG.there.be.PRS.3SG.S

‘There is no remedy for someone culpable.’ (Lit. ‘Culpable remedy there is not.’) (Existential)

آنچه می‌رسند تو از پیش مگو.

- (26) Aanche maporsand to az pish magoo
what NEG.ask.PRS.3PL.S you from before NEG.say.IMP.2SG.S

⁴ Bam is a city in Kerman province in Iran.

‘What you are not asked, don’t reply in advance.’ (Lit. ‘What (they) don’t ask you from advance don’t say.’)
(Verbal)

هر که به امید همسایه نشست ، شب گرسنه می خوابد.

- (27) Har ke be omide hamsaayeh neshast gorosneh *mikhaabad.*
every one to hope.of neighbour sit.PRS.SBJV.3SG.S hungry sleep.PRS.3SG.S

‘He who depends on his neighbour goes to bed hungry at night.’ (Lit. ‘Everyone to the hope of neighbour sits, hungry sleeps.’) (Behavioural)

هر که را زر در ترازوست زور در بازوست.

- (28) Harke raa zar dar taraazo-ost zoor dar bazo-ost.
whoever DOM gold in scale-be.PRS.3SG.S power in arm-be.PRS.3SG.S

‘Whoever has gold in his weighing scales has power in his arm.’ (Lit. ‘Whoever gold in scale is power in arm is.’) (Relational circumstantial identifying)

The results of the analysis of Theme and Rheme for the Persian proverbs indicated that, surprisingly, no process took place in the Theme in the entire corpus at all. On the other hand, the results of the analysis for Rheme showed that the five most dominant processes in the Persian corpus were: material (N = 103) and relational intensive attributive (N = 79), relational intensive identifying (N = 18), and finally mental and relational possessive attributive (N = 15) equally. This order was followed by existential (N = 9), relational circumstantial attributive (N = 10), verbal (N = 7), and relational circumstantial identifying and behavioural in equal measure (N = 1). Only one process was not recorded in the Rheme in the Persian clauses, namely relational possessive identifying (Figure 2):

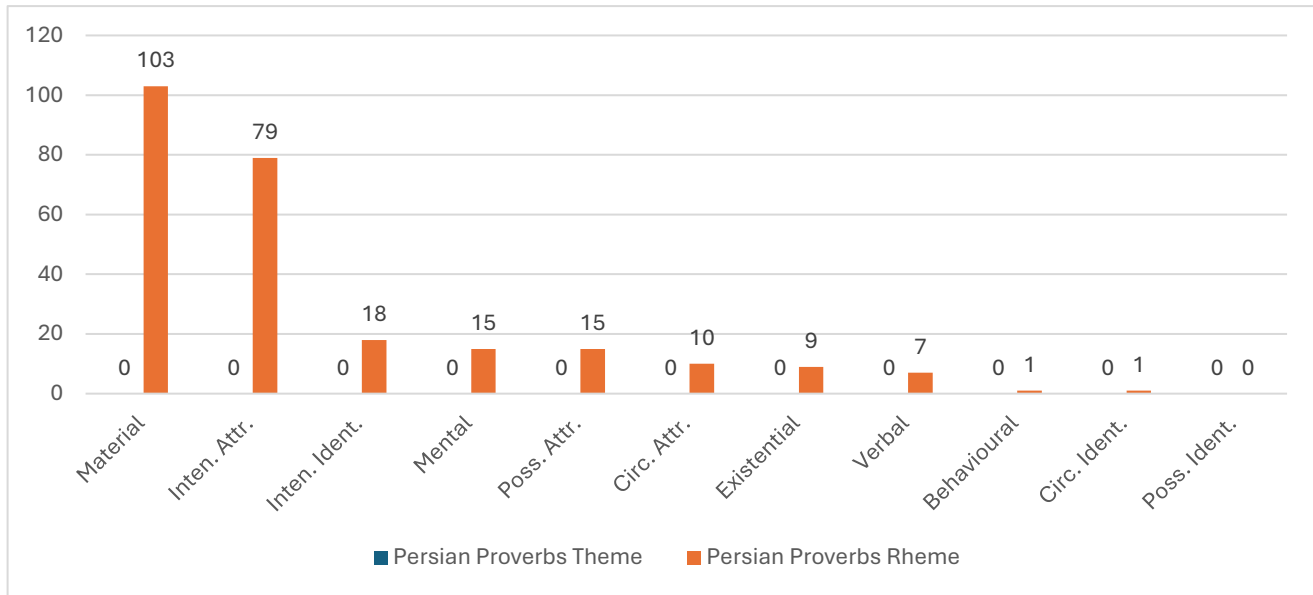


Fig. 2 Frequency of the process types in Theme and Rheme in the Persian proverbs

Since no process type was identified in the Theme position of the Persian corpus, this section will proceed directly to the analysis of the process types occurring in the Rheme, focusing on their relative frequency in percentage terms. The ordering is as follows: material (39.9%), relational intensive attributive (30.6%), relational intensive identifying (7%), mental and relational possessive attributive (5.8%). This order is followed by relational circumstantial attributive (3.9%), existential (3.5%), verbal (2.7%), relational circumstantial identifying and behavioural equally (0.4%). There is no case of relational possessive identifying in this corpus (Table 5):

Persian Proverbs					
Process Types	Theme	Percentage	Process Types	Rheme	Percentage
Material	0	0%	Material	103	39.9%
Mental	0	0%	Intensive Attributive	79	30.6%
Verbal	0	0%	Intensive Identifying	18	7.0%
Behavioural	0	0%	Mental	15	5.8%
Existential	0	0%	Possessive Attributive	15	5.8%
Intensive Identifying	0	0%	Circumstantial Attributive	10	3.9%
Intensive Attributive	0	0%	Existential	9	3.5%
Possessive Identifying	0	0%	Verbal	7	2.7%
Possessive Attributive	0	0%	Behavioural	1	0.4%
Circumstantial Attributive	0	0%	Circumstantial Identifying	1	0.4%
Circumstantial Identifying	0	0%	Possessive Identifying	0	0%
Total	0	0%	Total	258	100.00%

Table 5 Relative frequency of the process types in Theme and Rheme in the Persian proverbs

3.1.3 Spanish

The analysis of the Theme and Rheme in the Spanish corpus showed that, except for three types of relational process, namely possessive identifying, circumstantial attributive, and circumstantial identifying, all six types of process appeared in the Theme, while in the Rheme circumstantial identifying and behavioural were not recorded. These are some examples of the process types in the Theme and Rheme in the Spanish corpus:

(29) No hay enemigo pequeño.

not there.be.PRS.3SG.S enemy small

‘There is no small enemy.’ (Lit. ‘Not there is enemy small.’) (Existential in Theme)

(30) No vendas la piel del oso antes de cazar-lo.

not sell.IMP.2SG.S the skin of.the bear before of hunt.INF-3SG.O

‘Don’t sell the bear’s skin before you hunt it.’ (Lit. ‘Not sell the skin of the bear before hunting it.’) (Material in Theme)

- (31) No *te* *acostarás* sin saber una cosa más.
 not you.REFL lay down.FUT.3SG.S without know.INF one thing more
 ‘Don’t sleep without learning one more thing.’ (Lit. ‘You will not yourself lay down without knowing one thing more.’) (Behavioural in Theme)
- (32) *Piensa* el ladrón que todos son de su condición.
 think.PRS.3SG.S the thief that everybody be.PRS.3PL.S of 3.POSS.SG condition
 ‘The thief thinks everybody is a thief.’ (Lit. ‘Thinks the thief that everybody are from his condition.’) (Mental in Theme)
- (33) *Dijo* la sartén a la caldera: “Quítate
 say.PST.3SG.S the pan to the kettle remove.IMP.2SG.O.REFL
 allá negra”.
 there black
 ‘The pan said to the pot: “Remove yourself you black thing”.’ (Lit. ‘Said the pan to the pot: “Remove yourself there, black”.’) (Verbal in Theme)
- (34) *Es* buena noticia el que no las haya.
 be.PRS.3SG.S good news the that not 3PL.O be.PRS.SBJV.3SG.S
 ‘No news is good news.’ (Lit. ‘Is good news the that not they are.’) (Relational intensive identifying in Theme)
- (35) No *es* tan bravo el león como lo pintan.
 not be.PRS.3SG.S so brave the lion like 3SG.N.O paint.PRS.3PL.S
 ‘The lion is not as brave as they say.’ (Lit. ‘Not is so brave the lion as they paint him.’) (Relational intensive attributive in Theme)
- (36) *Tiene* mucho ruido y pocas nueces.
 have.PRS.3SG.S a.lot.of noise and few walnut.PL
 ‘Has a lot of noise and a few walnuts.’ (Lit. ‘Has a lot of noise and few walnuts.’) (Relational possessive attributive in Theme)
- (37) A quien dan no *escoge*.
 to whom give.PRS.3PL.S not choose.PRS.3SG.S
 ‘Who receives does not choose.’ (Lit. ‘To whom they give, does not choose.’) (Material in Rheme)
- (38) Cada uno en su casa *es* rey.

every one in 3.POSS.SG house be.PRS.3SG.S king

‘Every one is a king in his house.’ (Lit. ‘Every one in his house is king.’) (Relational intensive attributive in Rheme)

- (39) Los arboles no dejan ver el bosque.
the.PL tree.PL not permit.PRS.3PL.S see.INF the woods

‘The trees don’t allow the woods to be seen.’ (Lit. ‘The trees no permit see the woods.’) (Mental in Rheme)

- (40) Cada uno tiene lo que se merece.
every one have.PRS.3SG.S the that REFL deserve.PRS.3SG.S

‘Everyone gets what he deserves.’ (Lit. ‘Everyone has what that himself deserves.’) (Relational possessive attributive in Rheme)

- (41) De la abundancia del corazón habla la boca.
of the fullness of.de heart talk.PRS.3SG.S the mouth

‘The mouth speaks from the fullness of the heart.’ (Lit. ‘From the fullness of the heart speaks the mouth.’) (Verbal in Rheme)

- (42) Poderoso caballero es Don dinero.
powerful gentleman be.PRS.3SG.S Mr. money

‘Money is power.’ (Lit. ‘Powerful gentleman is Mr. money.’) (Relational intensive identifying in Rheme)

- (43) A buen hambre no hay pan duro.
to good hunger not there.be.PRS.3SG.S bread hard

‘There is no stale bread for a hungry man.’ (Lit. ‘To a good hunger not there a bread stale.’) (Existential in Rheme)

- (44) Mente sana está en cuerpo sano.
mind healthy be.PRS.3SG.S in body healthy

‘A healthy mind is in a healthy body.’ (Lit. ‘Mind healthy is in body healthy.’) (Relational circumstantial attributive in Rheme)

- (45) Lo que es común es de ningún.
the that be.PRS.3SG.S common be.PRS.3SG.S of none

‘What is shared belongs to no one.’ (Lit. ‘That which is common is of nobody.’) (Relational possessive identifying in Rheme)

The analysis of the Theme and Rheme in the Spanish corpus revealed that, in the Theme, two processes shared the highest occurrence: existential (N = 8) and material (N = 7). The results also showed that the least frequent processes in the Theme were mental, verbal, and relational intensive identifying (N = 2). There was only one case (N = 1) of relational possessive attributive and relational intensive attributive in the Theme of this corpus. According to the results, there were three processes that did not appear in the Theme of the Spanish corpus at all: relational possessive identifying, relational circumstantial attributive, and circumstantial identifying. Based on the results of the analysis of Rheme, the most dominant processes were material (N = 108), relational intensive attributive (N = 62), mental (N = 21), and relational possessive attributive (N = 19). The processes in the middle range were: verbal (N = 8), and relational intensive identifying (N = 6), existential (N = 5), relational circumstantial attributive (N = 2), and relational possessive identifying (N = 1). Behavioural and relational circumstantial identifying were the only two processes with no record in the Rheme in the Spanish corpus (Figure 3):

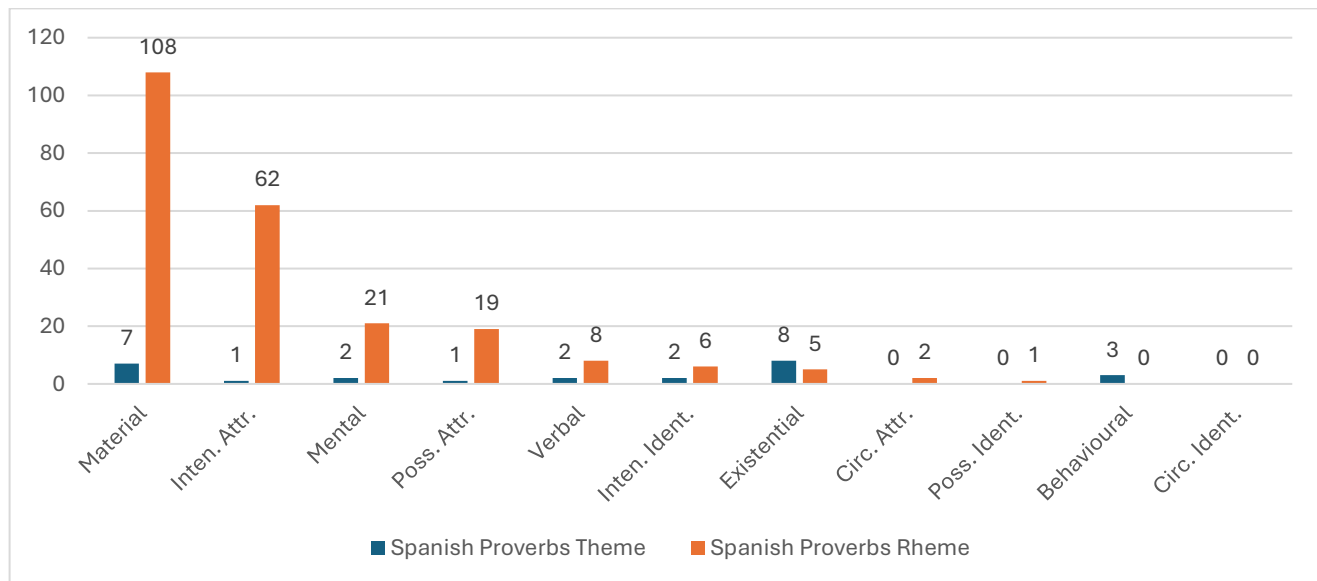


Fig. 2 Frequency of the process types in Theme and Rheme in the Spanish proverbs

The relative frequency of the process types in the Theme and the Rheme in the Spanish corpus is presented in Table 6. In the analysis of Theme, the order of the most dominant processes in the Spanish corpus were as follows: existential (30.7%), material (26.9%), behavioural (11.5%), with mental, verbal, and relational intensive identifying in equal measure (7.7%) followed by relational intensive attributive and possessive attributive (3.8%). On the other hand, the relative frequency of the process types in the Rheme in the Spanish corpus appeared in the following order: material (46.5%), relational intensive attributive (26.7%), mental (9%), and relational possessive attributive (8.1%), respectively. The other processes in the middle

range were verbal (3.4%), relational intensive identifying (2.5%), existential (2.1%), relational circumstantial attributive (0.8%), and relational possessive identifying (0.4%). Behavioural and relational circumstantial identifying were the only two processes with no record in the Rheme in the Spanish corpus:

Spanish Proverbs					
Process Types	Theme	Percentage	Process Types	Rheme	Percentage
Existential	8	30.7%	Material	108	46.5%
Material	7	26.9%	Intensive Attributive	62	26.7%
Behavioural	3	11.5%	Mental	21	9.0%
Verbal	2	7.7%	Possessive Attributive	19	8.1%
Mental	2	7.7%	Verbal	8	3.4%
Intensive Identifying	2	7.7%	Intensive Identifying	6	2.5%
Intensive Attributive	1	3.8%	Existential	5	2.1%
Possessive Attributive	1	3.8%	Circumstantial Attributive	2	0.8%
Possessive Identifying	0	0%	Possessive Identifying	1	0.4%
Circumstantial Attributive	0	0%	Behavioural	0	0%
Circumstantial Identifying	0	0%	Circumstantial Identifying	0	0.0%
Total	26	100%	Total	232	100%

Table 6 Relative frequency of the process types in Theme and Rheme in the Spanish proverbs

3.1.4 Quantitative cross-language analysis

Figures 4 and 5 provide a summary of the relative frequency of the process types occurring in both the Theme and the Rheme across the three corpora. In the analysis of process types in the Theme (Figure 4), the order of presentation of the relative frequencies was as follows: material (84.6%) and behavioural (15.3%) in English corpus, no process in Persian corpus, and existential (30.7%), material (26.9%), behavioural (11.5%), mental, relational intensive identifying, and verbal equally (7.7%), relational intensive attributive and relational possessive attributive equally (3.8%) in the Spanish corpus.

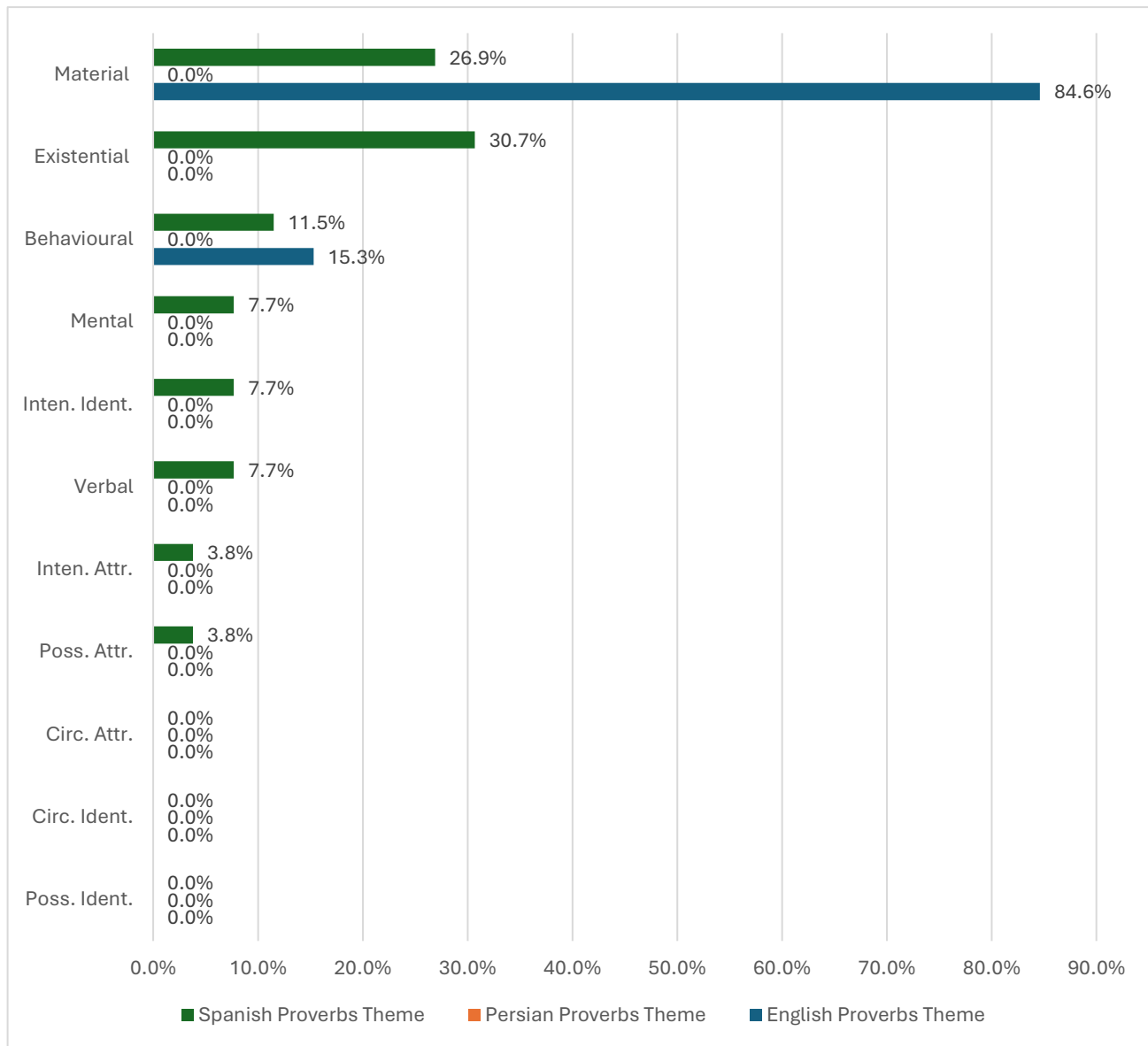


Fig. 3 Comparative ratio of the process types in Theme across the three languages

On the other hand, the relative frequencies of process types in the Rheme (Figure 5) across the three corpora were as follows. Firstly, in the English corpus, relational intensive attributive (35.5%) and material (34.2%) processes were the most frequent, followed by mental and existential processes (6.1%), relational intensive identifying (5.7%), relational possessive attributive and relational circumstantial attributive (3.6%), verbal (3.2%), relational circumstantial identifying (0.8%), and behavioural and relational possessive identifying (0.4%). Secondly, in the Persian corpus, material processes (39.9%) predominated, followed by relational intensive attributive (30.6%), relational intensive identifying (7%), mental and relational possessive attributive (5.8%), relational circumstantial attributive (3.9%), existential (3.5%), verbal (2.7%), and behavioural and relational circumstantial identifying (0.4%). Finally, in the Spanish corpus, material processes (46.5%) were the most frequent, followed by relational intensive attributive (26.7%), mental (9%), relational possessive attributive (8.1%),

verbal (3.4%), relational intensive identifying (2.5%), existential (2.1%), relational circumstantial attributive (0.8%), and relational possessive identifying (0.4%). These results indicate a dominant presence of material and relational intensive attributive processes in all three corpora, though with slight variations in their relative frequencies.

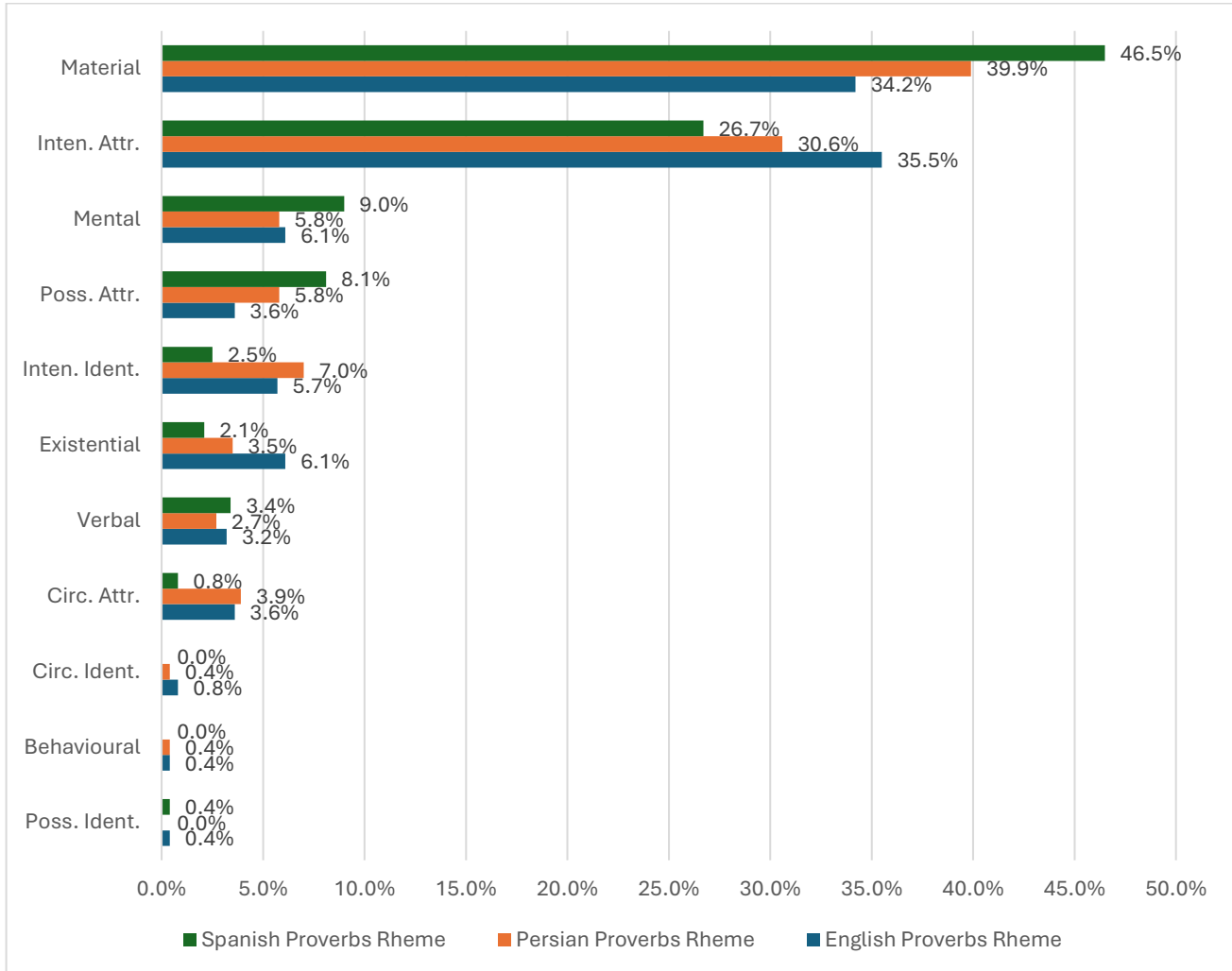


Fig. 4 Comparative ratio of the process types in Rheme across the three languages

Based on these results (Table 7), the analysis of Theme showed that material (84.6%, N = 11) and behavioural (15.3%, N = 2) were the most dominant processes in the Theme in the English corpus, while existential (30.7%, N = 8) and material (26.9%, N = 7) were the most dominant processes in Theme in the Spanish corpus followed by behavioural (11.5%, N = 3). Regarding the least frequent process types, the results indicated mental, verbal, and relational intensive identifying in the same proportion (7.7%, N = 2) in the Spanish corpus, while no process type appeared in the English corpus as the least frequent, since material and behavioural were the only process types to appear in the English corpus.

The analysis of the Rheme in the English corpus showed that the most frequent processes were: relational intensive attributive (35.5%, N = 87), material (34.2%, N = 84), mental and existential (6.1%, N = 15). However, the same order does not follow in the Rheme of the Persian corpus. In the Persian corpus, this order was recorded as material (39.9%, N = 103), relational intensive attributive (30.6%, N = 79), and relational intensive identifying (7%, N = 18). In the analysis of Rheme in the Spanish corpus, the order of the dominant process types appeared as material (46.5%, N = 108), relational intensive attributive (26.7%, N = 62), followed by mental (9%, N = 21), although with a sharp difference in frequency with the former, relational intensive attributive. The remaining processes in the Rheme of the English corpus is as follows: relational intensive identifying (5.7%, N = 14), relational possessive attributive and relational circumstantial attributive (3.6%, N = 9), verbal (3.2%, N = 8), relational circumstantial identifying (0.8%, N = 2), behavioural and relational possessive identifying (0.4%, N = 1). In the Persian corpus, the order was followed by mental and relational possessive attributive (5.8%, N = 15), relational circumstantial attributive (3.9%, N = 10), existential (3.5%, N = 9), verbal (2.7%, N = 7), behavioural and relational circumstantial identifying (0.4%, N = 1). In the Spanish corpus, process types were followed by relational possessive attributive (8.1%, N = 19), verbal (3.4%, N = 8), relational intensive identifying (2.5%, N = 6), existential (2.1%, N = 5), relational circumstantial attributive (0.8%, N = 2), and relational possessive identifying (0.4%, N = 1):

	English Proverbs		Persian Proverbs		Spanish Proverbs		Total Items	Total
Process type	Theme	Rheme	Theme	Rheme	Theme	Rheme	Theme	Rheme
Material	11 84.6%	84 34.2%	0 0%	103 39.9%	7 26.9%	108 46.5%	18 46.1%	295 40.1%
Intensive Attributive	0 0%	87 35.5%	0 0%	79 30.6%	1 3.8%	62 26.7%	1 2.5%	228 31.1%
Mental	0 0%	15 6.1%	0 0%	15 5.8%	2 7.7%	21 9.0%	2 5.1%	51 6.9%
Possessive Attributive	0 0%	9 3.6%	0 0%	15 5.8%	1 3.8%	19 8.1%	1 2.5%	43 5.8%
Intensive Identifying	0 0%	14 5.7%	0 0%	18 7.0%	2 7.7%	6 2.5%	2 5.1%	38 5.1%
Existential	0 0%	15 6.1%	0 0%	9 3.5%	8 30.7%	5 2.1%	8 20.5%	29 3.9%
Verbal	0 0%	8 3.2%	0 0%	7 2.7%	2 7.7%	8 3.4%	2 5.1%	23 3.1%
Circumstantial Attributive	0 0%	9 3.6%	0 0%	10 3.9%	0 0%	2 0.8%	0 0%	21 2.8%
Behavioural	2 15.3%	1 0.4%	0 0%	1 0.4%	3 11.5%	0 0.0%	5 12.8%	2 0.2%
Circumstantial Identifying	0 0%	2 0.8%	0 0%	1 0.4%	0 0%	0 0%	0 0%	3 0.4%
Possessive Identifying	0 0%	1 0.4%	0 0%	0 0%	0 0%	1 0.4%	0 0%	2 0.2%
Total	13 100%	245 100%	0 100%	258 100%	26 100%	232 100%	39 100%	735 100%

Table 7 Comparative relative frequency of the process types in Theme and Rheme across the three languages

The comparison of the Theme and Rheme positions based on the quantitative results reveals notable differences in the distribution of process types. In the Theme, material processes are the most frequent, reflecting a focus on actions and events as points of departure in discourse. Material processes were followed by existential processes, which indicates significant emphasis on introducing or presenting entities into the discourse. Other process types such as intensive identifying, mental, and verbal processes appear less frequently, suggesting limited emphasis on identity, cognition, and communication in the thematic development.

In contrast, the Rheme shows a significant increase in the frequency of intensive attributive processes compared to the Theme, which marks the Rheme as the focus of evaluation or categorization. Material processes remain prominent in the Rheme, which suggests a focus on actions or events in section generally devoted to the introduction of new information, while existential processes decrease quite significantly, which involves thematically highlighting the existence or presence of entities. Additionally, mental and possessive attributive processes are more frequent in the Rheme than in the Theme,

emphasizing cognition and relational meaning in information focus. Behavioural and Circumstantial processes are more common in the Theme, but both are less frequent in the Rheme. Overall, the distribution of process types differs between the Theme and Rheme, with certain processes appearing more frequently in one position than the other.

To examine the relationship between process types in the Theme across the three corpora, a Chi-Square test of independence was conducted. The test indicated no significant association between language and process type, as the calculated value ($\chi^2 = 14.42$) was below the critical threshold ($\chi^2_{(20)} = 31.41$, $p = 0.05$). Degrees of freedom were determined by $(\text{columns} - 1) \times (\text{rows} - 1)$, resulting in 20. A follow-up test excluding the Persian corpus—where no process types appeared in the Theme—also showed no association between English and Spanish ($\chi^2 = 14.63 < \chi^2_{(10)} = 18.31$).

A Chi-Square test of independence was conducted to examine the relationship between process types in the Rheme across the three corpora. The test revealed a significant association between language and process type, as the calculated value ($\chi^2 = 33.95$) exceeded the critical threshold ($\chi^2_{(20)} = 31.41$, $p = 0.05$). Pairwise comparisons showed no significant relationship between English and Persian ($\chi^2 = 14.93 < \chi^2_{(10)} = 18.31$), but significant associations were found between English and Spanish ($\chi^2 = 28.11 > 18.31$) and between Persian and Spanish ($\chi^2 = 21.56 > 18.31$).

3.2 Participants

This section examines the second component of the TRANSITIVITY system in Systemic Functional Grammar (SFG), namely the participants. A participant represents an entity involved in the process expressed within a clause and each process includes at least one participant. In each example, the participant in the Theme and in the Rheme will be highlighted in italics, and the name of the type of participant will be included in parentheses at the end of the proverb:

3.2.1 *English*

The analysis of the results of the English corpus in this research showed that a variety of participants appeared in this corpus both in the Theme and the Rheme. These are highlighted in the examples given below. However, there were some participants that were not recorded in the Theme, such as Scope, Recipient, Behaviour, Verbiage, Target, Attributor, Inducer,

and Beneficiary. As regards the Rheme, the participants not represented in the corpus were Senser, Receiver, and Inducer (Figure 6):

- (46) *A miss* is as good as a mile. (Carrier in Theme)
- (47) *One scabbed sheep* will infect the whole flock. (Actor in Theme)
- (48) *Kindness* is the noblest weapon to conquer with. (Identified in Theme)
- (49) *A good arrow* cannot be made of a sow's tail. (Goal in Theme)
- (50) *The crow* thinks her own birds fairest. (Senser in Theme)
- (51) *Travellers* may lie by authority. (Sayer in Theme)
- (52) *The greatest wealth* is to live content with little. (Identifier in Theme)
- (53) *Better* late than never. (Attribute in Theme)
- (54) *The value of prosperity* is known by adversity. (Phenomenon in Theme)
- (55) *Wise men* may receive benefit by hearing fools. (Client in Theme)
- (56) *A rolling stone* gathers no moss. (Receiver in Theme)
- (57) *The longest purse* will prevail. (Existent in Theme)
- (58) Stolen waters are *sweet*. (Attribute in Rheme)
- (59) A little fire may kindle *a great matter*. (Goal in Rheme)
- (60) There is *honour* among thieves. (Existent in Rheme)
- (61) Distrust is *the mother of security*. (Identifier in Rheme)
- (62) Hunger never saw *bad bread*. (Phenomenon in Rheme)
- (63) The best apple is taken by *the pig*. (Actor in Rheme)
- (64) Fortune favors *the bold*⁵. (Client in Rheme)
- (65) Your enemies tell *your faults*. (Verbiage in Rheme)
- (66) One scabbed sheep will infect *a whole flock*. (Scope in Rheme)
- (67) In wine is *truth*. (Carrier in Rheme)
- (68) In the kingdom of the blind the one-eyed man is *king*. (Identified in Rheme)
- (69) Nothing is impossible to *willing minds*. (Beneficiary in Rheme)
- (70) The sow teaches *Minerva*. (Recipient in Rheme)

⁵ 'The bold' is considered as Client because it has no preposition.

- (71) Don't cry *over spilt milk*. (Behaviour in Rheme)
- (72) Out of the abundance of the heart *the mouth* speaks. (Sayer in Rheme)
- (73) The pot calls *the kettle* black. (Target in Rheme)
- (74) As you make your bed, *you* must lie on it. (Behaver in Rheme)
- (75) All cats are black at *nigh*⁶. (Attributor in Rheme)

Regarding the participants in the English proverbs that appeared in the Theme of the clause, the following participants appeared in descending order: Carrier (N = 98), Actor (N = 65), Identified (N = 14), Goal (N = 13), Senser (N = 10), Sayer (N = 6), Identifier, Attribute and Phenomenon (N = 2). Client, Receiver, and Existent only occurred once (N = 1) in the Theme in the English corpus, whereas some participants did not appear at all in the Theme, namely Recipient, Behaver, Behaviour, Scope, Verbiage, Target, Inducer, Attributor, and Beneficiary. By contrast, the analysis of the Rheme in the English proverbs showed that the most dominant participants were as follows: Attribute (N = 92), Goal (N = 37), Existent (N = 15), Identifier (N = 14), and Phenomenon (N = 10), Actor (N = 5), Client and Verbiage (N = 4), Scope, Identified, and Carrier (N = 3). The participants, which occurred twice (N = 2), were Beneficiary, Recipient and Behaviour, and. Behaver, Target, Attributor, and Sayer were recorded only once (N = 1). The participants, which were not recorded in the Rheme in this corpus, were Senser, Receiver, and Inducer:

⁶ 'Night' makes the cats appear black which is why it is the Attributor.

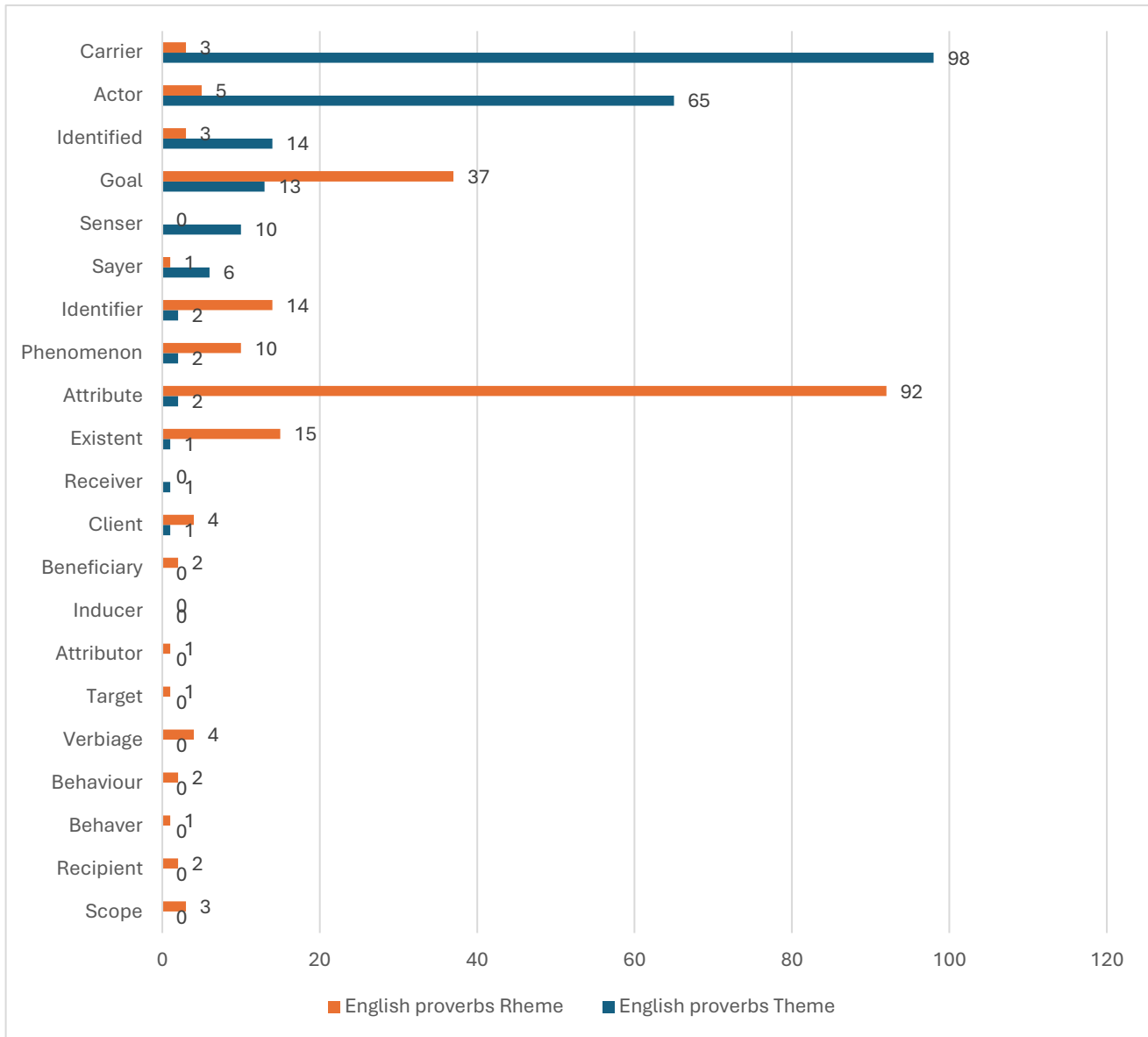


Fig. 5 Frequency of the participant types in Theme and Rheme in the English proverbs

The relative frequencies of the participants in the Theme and the Rheme in the proverbs from the English corpus are presented in Table 8, with a focus on the percentage distribution. The most frequent participants in the Theme were: Carrier (45.6%), Actor (30.2%), Identified (6.5%), Goal (6%), Senser (4.7%), Sayer (2.8%), Identifier, Attribute, and Phenomenon (0.9%). Client, Receiver, and Existent only occurred once (0.5%) in the Theme in the English corpus. As for the Rheme, the order of the most frequent participants in this part of the clause is as follows: Attribute (46%), Goal (18.5%), Existent (7.5%), Identifier (7%), Phenomenon (5%), Actor (2.5%), Client and Verbiage (2%), Scope, Carrier and Identified (1.5%). The participants, which occurred twice (1%), were Beneficiary, Recipient, and Behaviour. Sayer, Target, Behaver and Attributor were recorded only once (0.5%).

English Proverbs					
Participant Types	Theme	Percentage	Participant Types	Rheme	Percentage
Carrier	98	45.6%	Attribute	92	46.0%
Actor	65	30.2%	Goal	37	18.5%
Identified	14	6.5%	Existent	15	7.5%
Goal	13	6.0%	Identifier	14	7.0%
Senser	10	4.7%	Phenomenon	10	5.0%
Sayer	6	2.8%	Actor	5	2.5%
Identifier	2	0.9%	Client	4	2.0%
Attribute	2	0.9%	Verbiage	4	2.0%
Phenomenon	2	0.9%	Scope	3	1.5%
Client	1	0.5%	Carrier	3	1.5%
Receiver	1	0.5%	Identified	3	1.5%
Existent	1	0.5%	Beneficiary	2	1.0%
Behaver	0	0.0%	Recipient	2	1.0%
Behaviour	0	0.0%	Behaviour	2	1.0%
Scope	0	0.0%	Sayer	1	0.5%
Verbiage	0	0.0%	Target	1	0.5%
Target	0	0.0%	Behaver	1	0.5%
Recipient	0	0.0%	Attributor	1	0.5%
Attributor	0	0.0%	Receiver	0	0.0%
Inducer	0	0.0%	Inducer	0	0.0%
Beneficiary	0	0.0%	Senser	0	0.0%
Total	215	100.0%	Total	200	100.0%

Table 8 Relative frequency of the participant types in Theme and Rheme in the English proverbs

3.2.2 Persian

There were a variety of participants in the Persian corpus (Figure 7), although some of them, such as Client, Recipient, Behaviour, Receiver, Target, Attributor, and Inducer, did not appear in the Theme, and others, such as Behaver, Attributor, behaviour and Inducer, did not appear in the Rheme. Examples of the participants in the Theme and Rheme in the Persian corpus are listed below:

وقت طلا است.

- (76) *Vaght* *talla* *ast.*
time gold be.PRS.3SG.S

‘Time is gold.’ (Lit. ‘Time gold is.’) (Carrier in Theme)

آدم دانا به نیشتر نزنند مشیت.

- (77) *Aadame daanaa be nishtar nazanad mosht.*
 man.of wise to lance NEG.do.PRS.3SG.S punch

‘A wise man does not punch a lance.’ (Lit. ‘Man of wise to lance does not punch.’) (Actor in Theme)

آب در هاون می کوید.

- (78) *Aab dar haavan mikoobad.*
 water in mortar pound.PRS.3SG.S

‘He pounds water in a mortar.’ (Lit. ‘Water in mortar (he) pounds.’) (Goal in Theme)

سکوت علامت رضاست.

- (79) *Sokoot_ alaamate reza-ast.*
 silence sign.of consent-be.PRS.3SG.S

‘Silence is the sign of consent.’ (Lit. ‘Silence sign of consent is.’) (Identified *sokoot* ‘silence’ in Theme and Identifier *alamate reza* ‘sign of consent’ in Rheme)

گل بی خار وجود ندارد.

- (80) *Gole bikhaar vojood nadaarad.*
 flower thornless exist NEG.do.PRS.3SG.S

‘There is no thornless flower.’ (Lit. ‘Flower thornless exist does not.’) (Existent in Theme)

گل بی عیب خداست.

- (81) *Gole bieyb khodast.*
 flower perfect God.be.PRS.3SG.S

‘God is the perfect flower.’ (Lit. ‘Flower perfect God is.’) (Identifier *gole bieyb* ‘flawless flower’ in Theme and Identified *khoda* ‘God’ in Rheme)

مایه عیش آدمی شکم است.

- (82) *Mayeye eyshe aadami shekam ast.*
 means.of happiness man stomach be.PRS.3SG.S

‘A man’s happiness is through the stomach.’ (Lit. ‘Means of happiness of man stomach is.’) (Attribute in Theme)

کافر همه را به کیش خود پندارد.

- (83) *Kaafar hame raa be kishe khod pendaarad.*

atheist all DOM to religion.of 3SG.M.REFL think.PRS.3SG.S

‘An atheist thinks everyone is an atheist.’ (Lit. ‘Atheist all to his religion thinks.’) (Senser in Theme)

حرف راست را باید از زبان بچه شنید.

(84) *Harfe raast raa baayad az zabaane bache shenid.*

word true DOM should from tongue.of child hear.PRS.SBJV.3SG.S

‘The truth should be heard from a child.’ (Lit. ‘Word true should from tongue of a child hear.’) (Phenomenon in Theme)

جهان‌دیده بسیار گوید دروغ.

(85) *Jahaandideh besyaar gooyad doroogh.*

worldly a.lot say.PRS.3SG.S lies

‘A worldly person lies a lot.’ (Lit. ‘Worldly a lot says lies.’) (Sayer in Theme)

عاقلان را یک اشارت بس بود.

(86) *Aaghelaan raa yek eshaarat bas bovad.*

wiseman.PL DOM one hint enough be.PRS.3SG.S

‘A hint is enough for the wise.’ (Lit. ‘Wises to one hint enough is.’) (Beneficiary in Theme)

هر که به امید همسایه نشست گرسنه می خوابد.

(87) *Har ke be omide hamsaayeh neshast gorosneh*

every one to hope.of neighbour sit.PRS.SBJV.3SG.S hungry

mikhaabad.

sleep.PRS.3SG.S

‘He who depends on his neighbour goes to bed hungry at night.’ (Lit. Everyone to the hope of neighbour sits, hungry sleeps.) (Behaver *Har ke be omide hamsaayeh neshast* ‘He who depends on the neighbour’ in Theme)

چیزی که نپرسند تو از پیش مگو.

(88) *Chizi ke naporsand to az pish magoo.*

thing that NEG.ask.PRS.3PL.S you from advance NEG.say.IMP.2SG.S

‘Don’t say in advance what you are not asked for.’ (Lit. ‘Thing that (they) don’t ask, you from before don’t say.’) (Verbiage in Theme)

سرنه را از سر گشادش می زند.

- (89) *Sornaa* *raa* *az* *sare* *goshaadash* *mizanad*.
 oboe DOM from head 3.POSS.loose play.PRS.3SG.S
 ‘He plays the oboe from its wrong end.’ (Lit. ‘Oboe from head loose plays.’) (Scope in Theme)
 میهمان تاسه روز عزیز است.
- (90) *Mihmaan* *taa* *se* *rooz* *aziz* *ast*.
 guest till three day.PL dear be.PRS.3SG.S
 ‘A guest is dear up to three days.’ (Lit. ‘Guest till three days dear is.’) (Attribute in Rheme)
 از کاه کوه می سازد.
- (91) *Az* *kaah* *kooh* *misaazad*.
 from hay mountain make.PRS.3SG.S
 ‘He makes a mountain out of hay.’ (Lit. ‘From hay mountain (he) makes.’) (Goal in Rheme)
 اگر لر به بازار نرود بازار می کنند.
- (92) *Agar* *Lor* *be* *baazaar* *naravad* *baazaar* *migandad*.
 if Lur to bazaar go.NEG..PRS.3SG.S bazaar spoil.3SG.PRS.S
 ‘If Lur doesn’t go to bazaar, bazaar spoils.’ (Lit. ‘If Lur to bazaar does not go, bazaar spoils.’) (Actor in Rheme)
 به هر کجا که روی آسمان همین رنگ است.
- (93) *Be* *har* *koja* *ke* *ravi* *aasemaan* *hamin rang* *ast*.
 to every where that go.PRS.SBJV.2SG.S sky same colour be.PRS.3SG.S
 ‘The sky is the same colour everywhere.’ (Lit. ‘To everywhere that (you) go, sky same color is.’) (Carrier in Rheme)
 مرگ فقیر و غنی نمی شناسد.
- (94) *Marg* *faghir o* *ghani* *nemishenaasad*.
 death poor and rich NEG.know.PRS.3PL.S
 ‘Death does not distinguish between poor and rich.’ (Lit. ‘Death poor and rich know does not.’) (Phenomenon in Rheme)
 بقال نمیگوید ماست من ترش است.
- (95) *Baghal* *nemigooyad* *maaste* *man* *torsh* *ast*.
 salesperson NEG.say.PRS.3SG.S yoghurt.of 1SG.POSS sour be.PRS.3SG.S

‘A salesperson does not say my yoghurt is sour.’ (Lit. ‘Salesperson doesn’t say yoghurt mine sour is.’) (Verbiage in Rheme)

گرم و سرد روزگار را (فلانی) دیده است.

- (96) Garm o sarde roozegaar raa (folani) dideh
warmth and cold.of life DOM he see.PTCP.3SG.S
ast.
be.PRS.3SG.S

‘He has seen the warmth and cold of life.’ (Lit. ‘Warmth and cold of life seen (he) has.’) (Senser in Rheme)

دیگ شراکت به جوش نمی آید.

- (97) Dige sheraakat be joosh nemiaayad.
pot cooperation to boiling.point NEG.reach.PRS.3SG.S

‘A jointly owned pot does not reach boiling point.’ (Lit. ‘Pot cooperation to boiling point reach does not.’) (Scope in Rheme)

نیست بالاتر از سیاهی رنگ.

- (98) Nist baalaatar az siyaahi rang.
NEG.there.be.PRS.3SG.S above from black colour

‘There is no colour above black.’ (Lit. ‘There is not above from black colour.’)

(Existent in Rheme)

خنده بر هر درد بی درمان دواست.

- (99) Khandeh bar har darde bidarmaan dava-ast
laughter to every disease incurable cure-be.PRS.3SG.S

‘Laughter is the cure for every incurable disease.’ (Lit. ‘Laughter to every disease incurable cure is.’)

(Beneficiary in Rheme)

سر و جان فدای شکم.

- (100) Sar o jaan fadaaye shekam.
head and life sacrifice.for.PRS.SBJV.3PL.S stomach

‘Be sacrificed the head and life for the stomach.’ (Lit. ‘Head and life sacrificed for stomach.’) (Client in Rheme)

کسی که بار شیشه دارد به دیوانه سنگ نمی زند.

- (101) Kasi ke baare shishe daarad
 3SG who load glass have.PRS.3SG.S
 be *divaaneh* sang nemizanad.
 to madman stone NEG.throw.PRS.3SG.S

‘He who has a load of glass should not throw stone at a madman.’ (Lit. ‘One who load of glass has to madman stone throw does not.’) (Recipient in Rheme)

تا نباشد چیزکی مردم نگویند چیزها.

- (102) Taa nabaashad chizaki *mardom* nagooyand chizhaa.
 until NEG.be.PRS.SBJV.3SG.S thing people NEG.speak.PRS.3PL.S things

‘People do not gossip until there is something.’ (Lit. Until is not something, people speak not things.) (Sayer in Rheme)

سوسکه به بچه اش میگفت قریون دست و پای بلوریت.

- (103) Sooske be *bachesh* migoft
 cockroach to 3.POSS.child.of say.PST.PROG.3SG.S
 ghorboone dast o paaye boloorit.
 die.PRS.1SG.S hand and leg 2.POSS.white

‘The cockroach said to its child: I die for your white limbs.’ (Lit. Cockroach to his child was saying: I die for limbs your white.) (Receiver in Rheme)

گاه باشد که کودکی نادان به خطا بر هدف زند تیری.

- (104) Gaah baashad ke koodaki nadaan
 sometimes be.SBJV.3SG.S that child ignorant
 be khataa bar *hadaf* zanad tiri.
 by mistake to target hit.PRS.3SG.S arrow

‘Sometimes a simple child might hit the target by chance.’ (Lit. Sometimes be that a child ignorant by mistake to target hits an arrow.) (Target in Rheme)

In the analysis of Theme in the Persian corpus, the four most frequent participants were Carrier (N = 96), Actor (N = 58), Goal (N = 33), and Identified (N = 14). There were some participants that did not occur at all in the Theme in the Persian corpus, namely Behaviour, Client, Receiver, Target, Attributor, recipient, and Inducer. In the analysis of Rheme, by contrast,

the four most dominant participants were: Attribute (N = 87), Goal (N = 38), Actor (N = 16), and Identifier (N = 13). Likewise, some participants like Behaviour, Behavior, Attributor, and Inducer did not either appear in the Rheme in the Persian corpus (Figure 7):

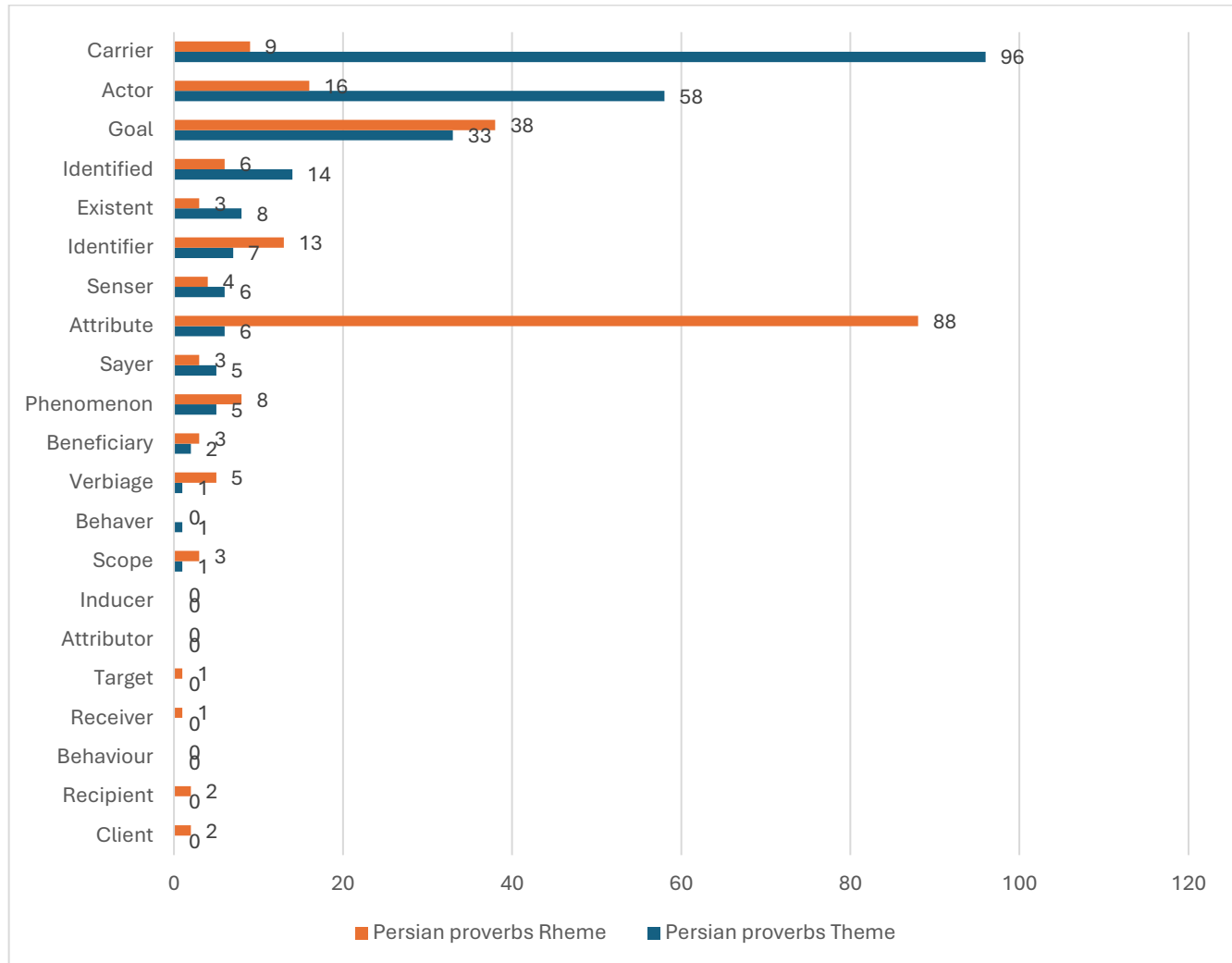


Fig. 6 Frequency of the participant types in Theme and Rheme in the Persian proverbs

If we consider the same results in terms of percentage frequencies (Table 9), the order of the most frequent participants in the Theme in the Persian corpus was as follows.: Carrier (39.5%), Actor (23.9%), Goal (13.6%), Identified (5.8%), Existent (3.3%), Senser, Identifier, and Attribute (2.5%), Sayer and Phenomenon (2.1%), Beneficiary (0.8%), Scope, Behavior, and Verbiage (0.4%). In the Rheme of the Persian proverbs the ordering was as follows: Attribute (42.6%), Goal (18.6%), Actor (7.8%), Identifier (6.4%), Carrier (4.4%), Phenomenon (3.9%), Identified (2.9%), Verbiage (2.5%), Senser (2%), Scope, Existent, and Beneficiary (1.5%), Client, Recipient, and Sayer (1%), with Receiver, and Target coming last with 0.5%:

Persian Proverbs					
Participant Types	Theme	Percentage	Participant Types	Rheme	Percentage
Carrier	96	39.5%	Attribute	88	43.1%
Actor	58	23.9%	Goal	38	18.6%
Goal	33	13.6%	Actor	16	7.8%
Identified	14	5.8%	Identifier	13	6.4%
Existent	8	3.3%	Carrier	9	4.4%
Identifier	6	2.5%	Phenomenon	8	3.9%
Attribute	6	2.5%	Identified	6	2.9%
Senser	6	2.5%	Verbiage	5	2.5%
Phenomenon	5	2.1%	Senser	4	2.0%
Sayer	5	2.1%	Scope	3	1.5%
Beneficiary	2	0.8%	Existent	3	1.5%
Behaver	1	0.4%	Beneficiary	3	1.5%
Verbiage	1	0.4%	Client	2	1.0%
Scope	1	0.4%	Recipient	2	1.0%
Behaviour	0	0.0%	Sayer	2	1.0%
Recipient	0	0.0%	Receiver	1	0.5%
Receiver	0	0.0%	Target	1	0.5%
Target	0	0.0%	Behaviour	0	0%
Client	0	0.0%	Behaver	0	0%
Inducer	0	0.0%	Attributor	0	0%
Attributor	0	0.0%	Inducer	0	0%
Total	242	100.0%	Total	204	100.0%

Table 9 Relative frequency of the participant types in Theme and Rheme in the Persian proverbs

3.2.3 Spanish

The Spanish corpus in the study showed all participant types except for five that did not appear either in the Theme or in the Rheme, such as Scope, Behaviour, Receiver, Target, and Attributor. Existent and Client did not appear in the Theme, and Behaver, Inducer and Beneficiary did not appear in the Rheme. Examples of participant types in the Spanish corpus are as follows:

- (105) *La unión hace la fuerza.*
the unity do.PRS.3SG.S the strength
‘Unity is strength.’ (Lit. ‘The unity does the strength.’) (Actor in Theme)

- (106) *El mentiroso ha de ser memorioso.*
the liar have.PRS.3SG.S of be.INF memorious

‘A liar should have a good memory.’ (Lit. ‘The liar should be memorious.’) (Carrier in Theme)

- (107) *Más vale maña que fuerza.*
more be.worth.PRS.3SG.S skill than strength

‘Skill is better than power.’ (Lit. ‘More is worth skill than strength.’) (Attribute in Theme)

- (108) *A moro viejo no le aprendas algarabía.*
to Arab old not 3SG.M.O teach.PRS.2SG.S Arabic

‘Don’t teach Arabic to an old Arab.’ (Lit. ‘To Arab old not him teach Arabic.’) (Recipient in Theme)

- (109) *Quien calla otorga.*
who silence.PRS.3SG.S consent.PRS.3SG.S

‘Who is shut up consents.’ (Lit. ‘Who shuts up consents.’) (Senser in Theme)

- (110) *La ocasión la pintan calva.*
the occasion 3SG.F.O paint.PRS.3PL.S bald

‘The opportunity should be taken immediately.’ (Lit. ‘The occasion her paint (they) bald.’) (Goal in Theme)

- (111) *Lo que fuerza no puede ingenio*
the that power not can.PRS.3SG.S ingenuity
lo ve.
3SG.N.O see.PRS.3SG.S

‘What can’t be done by power is done by ingenuity.’ (Lit. ‘That which power can’t ingenuity sees it.’)
(Phenomenon in Theme)

- (112) *Dinero llama dinero.*
money call.PRS.3SG.S money

‘Money calls money.’ (Lit. ‘Money calls money.’) (Sayer in Theme)

- (113) *El peor enemigo es el escondido.*
the worst enemy be.PRS.3SG.S the hidden

‘The worst enemy is the hidden one.’ (Lit. ‘The worst enemy is the hidden.’) (Identified *el peor enemigo* ‘the worst enemy’ in Theme and Identifier *el escondido* ‘the hidden’ in Rheme)

- (114) *Cada gallo canta en su muladar.*
every rooster sing.PRS.3SG.S in 3.POSS.SG dunghill

‘Every rooster sings on his dunghill.’ (Lit. ‘Every rooster sings in his dunghill.’) (Behaver in Theme)

- (115) *Poderoso caballero es Don Dinero.*
 powerful gentleman be.PRS.3SG.S Mr. money
 ‘Money is power.’ (Lit. ‘Powerful gentleman is Mr. Money.’) (Identifier *poderoso caballero* ‘powerful gentleman’ in Theme and Identified *Don Dinero* ‘Mr. Money’ in Rheme)
- (116) *Al más ruin puerco la mejor bellota pertenece.*
 to.the most heartless pig the best acorn PRS.3SG.S
 ‘He who wants something must pay something.’ (Lit. ‘He who something wants something his costs.’)
 (Beneficiary in Theme)
- (117) *De la abundancia del corazón habla la boca.*
 of the abundance of.the heart talk.PRS.3SG.S the mouth
 ‘The mouth speaks of the fullness of the heart.’ (Lit. ‘From the fullness of the heart, the mouth speaks.’)
 (Verbiage in Theme)
- (118) *Los árboles no dejan ver el bosque.*
the trees not permit.PRS.3PL.S see.INF the woods
 ‘You can’t see the wood for the trees’ (Lit. ‘The trees not let see the woods.’) (Inducer in Theme)
- (119) *El buen pagador heredero es de lo ajeno.*
 the good payer heir be.PRS.3SG.S of the stranger
 ‘A good payer is the heir of strangers.’ (Lit. ‘The good payer heir is of the stranger.’) (Attribute in Rheme)
- (120) *El mejor escribano echa un borrón.*
 the best writer make.PRS.3SG.S a blot
 ‘Even the best writer makes a blot.’ (Lit. ‘The best writer makes a blot.’) (Goal in Rheme)
- (121) *A cada cerdo le llega su San Martín.*
 to every pig 3SG.M.O reach.PRS.3SG.S 3.POSS.SG *San Martín.*
 ‘Every pig will see his San Martín.’ (Lit. ‘To every pig to him reaches his San Martín.’) (Actor in Rheme)
- (122) *No son todos los dedos de la mano iguales.*
 not be.PRS.3PL.S all the finger.PL of the hand equal.PL
 ‘Not all the fingers of the hand are the same.’ (Lit. ‘Not are all the fingers of the hand equal.’) (Carrier in Rheme)
- (123) *Ningún jorobado ve su joroba.*

no hunchback see.PRS.3SG.S 3.POSS.SG hump

‘Nobody sees their own defects.’ (Lit. ‘No hunchback sees his own hump.’) (Phenomenon in Rheme)

(124) No echéis margaritas a los cerdos.

not throw.IMP.2SG.S daisies to the pig.PL

‘Don’t throw daisies to pigs.’ (Lit. ‘Don’t throw daisies to the pigs.’) (Recipient in Rheme)

(125) No hay enemigo pequeño.

not there.be.PRS.3SG.S enemy small

‘There is no such thing as a small enemy.’ (Lit. ‘Not there is enemy small.’) (Existent in Rheme)

(126) Por sus frutos los conoceréis.

of 3.POSS.PL fruit.PL 3PL.O know.FUT.2PL.S

‘By their fruits you will know them.’ (Lit. ‘Of their fruits they know you.’) (Senser in Rheme)

(127) Boca dulce y bolsa abierta te abrirán todas

mouth sweet and bag open 2SG.O open.FUT.3PL.S all

las puertas.

the door.PL

‘Kindness and generosity will open all the doors for you.’ (Lit. ‘Mouth sweet and bag open for you open all the doors.’) (Client in Rheme)

(128) Los niños y los locos dicen las verdades.

the child.PL and the fool.PL say.PRS.3PL.S the truth.PL

‘Children and madmen tell the truth.’ (Lit. ‘Children and crazies say the truth.’) (Verbiage in Rheme)

(129) Después de beber cada uno dice su parecer.

after de drink.INF every one say.PRS.3SG.S 3.POSS.SG opinion

‘After drinking everyone reveals his thoughts.’ (Lit. ‘After the drinking every one says his opinion.’) (Sayer in Rheme)

The results for the analysis of Theme in the Spanish corpus showed that the top four most frequent participants were Actor (N = 72), Carrier (N = 47), Attribute (N = 19), and Recipient (N = 10). However, some participants, such as Target, Scope, Client, Behaviour, Receiver, Existent, and Attributor did not appear in this corpus. The analysis of Rheme showed that Attribute (N = 57), Goal (N = 36), Actor (N = 32), and Carrier (N = 26) were the most frequent participants. The participants

that were not used at all in the Rheme were Scope, Behaviour, Behavior, Receiver, Target, Attributor, Inducer, and Beneficiary (Figure 8):

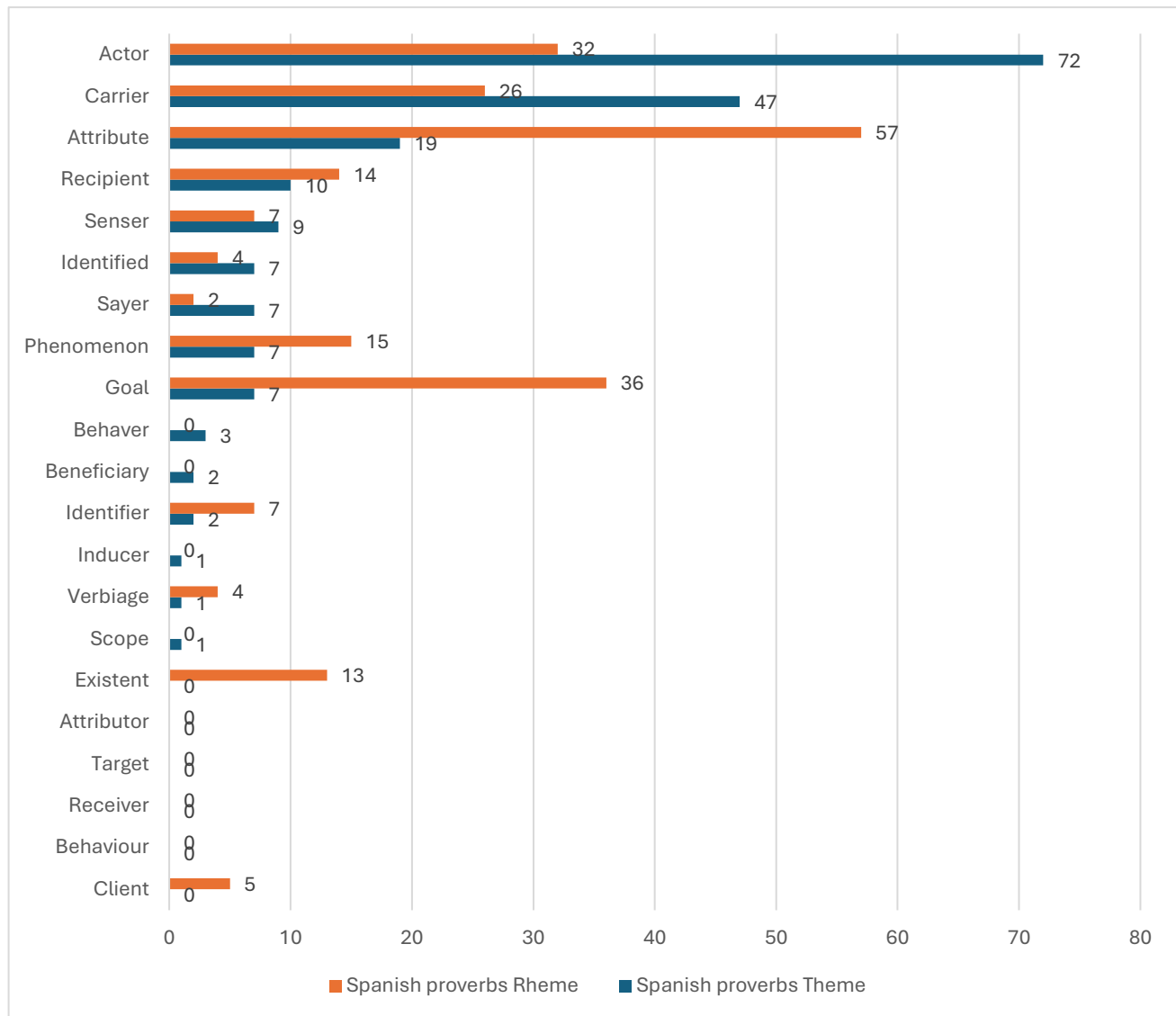


Fig. 7 Frequency of the participant types in Theme and Rheme in the Spanish proverbs

In terms of their relative frequency, the order of the participant types in the Theme in the Spanish corpus (Table 10) was as follows: Actor (37.5%), Carrier (24.5%), Attribute (9.9%), and Recipient (5.2%), Senser (4.7%), Goal, Phenomenon, Sayer and Identified (3.6%), Behaver (1.5%), Beneficiary and Identifier (1%), Verbiage and Inducer (0.5%). However, Scope, Client, Behaviour, Receiver, Target, Attributor, and Existent were not recorded as participants in the Theme in this corpus. The most frequent participants in the Rheme were as follows: Attribute (25.4%), Goal (16.1%), Actor (14.3%), and Carrier (11.6%), Phenomenon (6.7%), Recipient (6.3%), Existent (5.8%), Senser and Identifier (3.1%), Client (2.2%), Verbiage and Identified (1.8%), and Sayer (0.9%):

Spanish Proverbs					
Participant Types	Theme	Percentage	Participant Types	Rheme	Percentage
Actor	72	37.5%	Attribute	57	25.4%
Carrier	47	24.5%	Goal	36	16.1%
Attribute	19	9.9%	Actor	32	14.3%
Recipient	10	5.2%	Carrier	26	11.6%
Senser	9	4.7%	Phenomenon	15	6.7%
Goal	7	3.6%	Recipient	14	6.3%
Phenomenon	7	3.6%	Existent	13	5.8%
Sayer	7	3.6%	Senser	7	3.1%
Identified	7	3.6%	Identifier	7	3.1%
Behaver	3	1.5%	Client	5	2.2%
Identifier	2	1.0%	Verbiage	4	1.8%
Beneficiary	2	1.0%	Identified	4	1.8%
Verbiage	1	0.5%	Sayer	2	0.9%
Inducer	1	0.5%	Behaviour	0	0.0%
Existent	0	0.0%	Behaver	0	0.0%
Receiver	0	0.0%	Receiver	0	0.0%
Target	0	0.0%	Target	0	0.0%
Behaviour	0	0.0%	Scope	0	0.0%
Scope	0	0.0%	Attributor	0	0.0%
Client	0	0.0%	Inducer	0	0.0%
Attributor	0	0.0%	Beneficiary	0	0.0%
Total	194	100.0%	Total	222	100.0%

Table 10 Relative frequency of the participant types in Theme and Rheme in the Spanish proverbs

3.2.4 Quantitative cross-language analysis

Figures 9 and 10 present a summary of the relative frequency of the participant types across the three corpora. Firstly, as regards the Theme (Figure 29), it is worth noting that the first four most dominant participants in the Theme in the English corpus were Carrier (45.6%), Actor (30.2%), Identified (6.5%), and Goal (6%). In the Persian corpus, the first four frequent participant types were Carrier (39.5%), Actor (23.9%), Goal (13.6%), and Identified (5.8%). In the Spanish corpus, the first four participants in the Theme were Actor (37.5%), Carrier (24.5%), Attribute (9.9%), and Recipient (5.2%). The participants which follow these in the Theme in the English corpus were Senser (4.7%), Sayer (2.8%), Phenomenon, Attribute, and Identifier (0.9%). Client, Receiver, and Existent only occurred once (0.5%). In the Persian corpus, the analysis of Theme showed that the participants that followed were Existent (3.3%), Senser, Identifier, and Attribute (2.5%), Sayer and Phenomenon (2.1%), Beneficiary (0.8%), Scope, Behaver, and Verbiage (0.4%). In the Spanish corpus, in the Theme, they

were Sensor (4.7%), Goal, Phenomenon, Sayer and Identified (3.6%), Behaver (1.5%), Beneficiary and Identifier (1%), Verbiage and Inducer (0.5%).

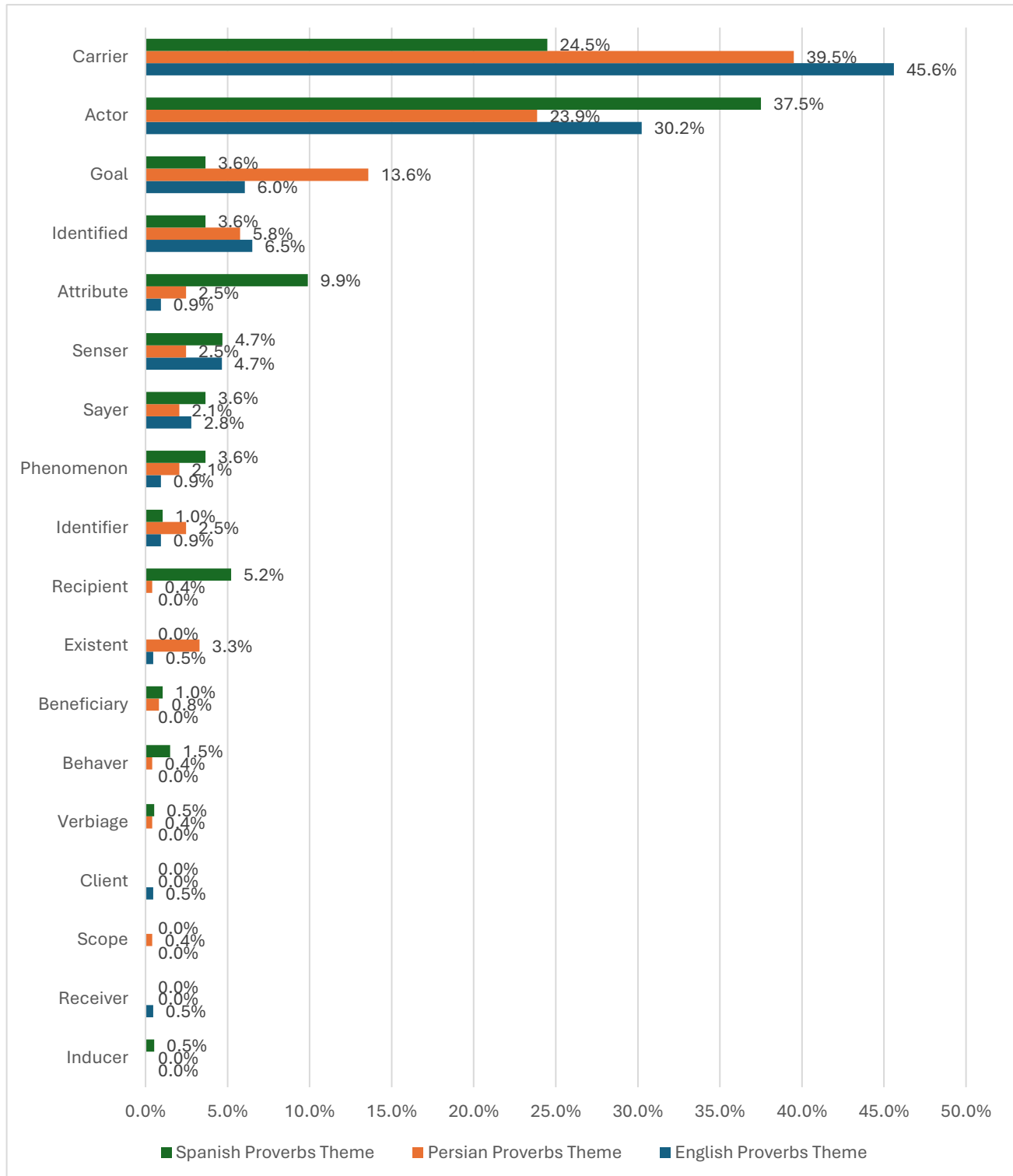


Fig. 8 Comparative ratio of the participant types in Theme across the three languages

Regarding the Rheme (Figure 10), the order of the most frequent participants in the English corpus was as follows: Attribute (46%), Goal (18.5%), Existent (7.5%), Identifier (7%), and Phenomenon (5%), Actor (2.5%), Client and Verbiage (2%), Scope and Carrier (1.5%). The participants that occurred twice (1%) were Recipient, Behaviour, Identified, and Beneficiary. Behavior, Target, and Sayer were recorded only once (0.5%). For the Persian corpus, the order in the Rheme was: Attribute (42.6%), Goal (18.6%), Actor (7.8%), and Identifier (6.4%), Carrier (4.4%), Phenomenon (3.9%), Identified (2.9%), Verbiage (2.5%), Senser (2%), Scope, Existent, and Beneficiary (1.5%), Client, Recipient, and Sayer (1%), Behaviour, Receiver, and Target (0.5%). For the Spanish corpus, the most frequent participants in the Rheme were Attribute (25.4%), Goal (16.1%), Actor (14.3%), Carrier (11.6%), Phenomenon (6.7%), Recipient (6.3%), Existent (5.8%), Senser and Identifier (3.1%), Client (2.2%), Verbiage and Identified (1.8%), and Sayer (0.9%).

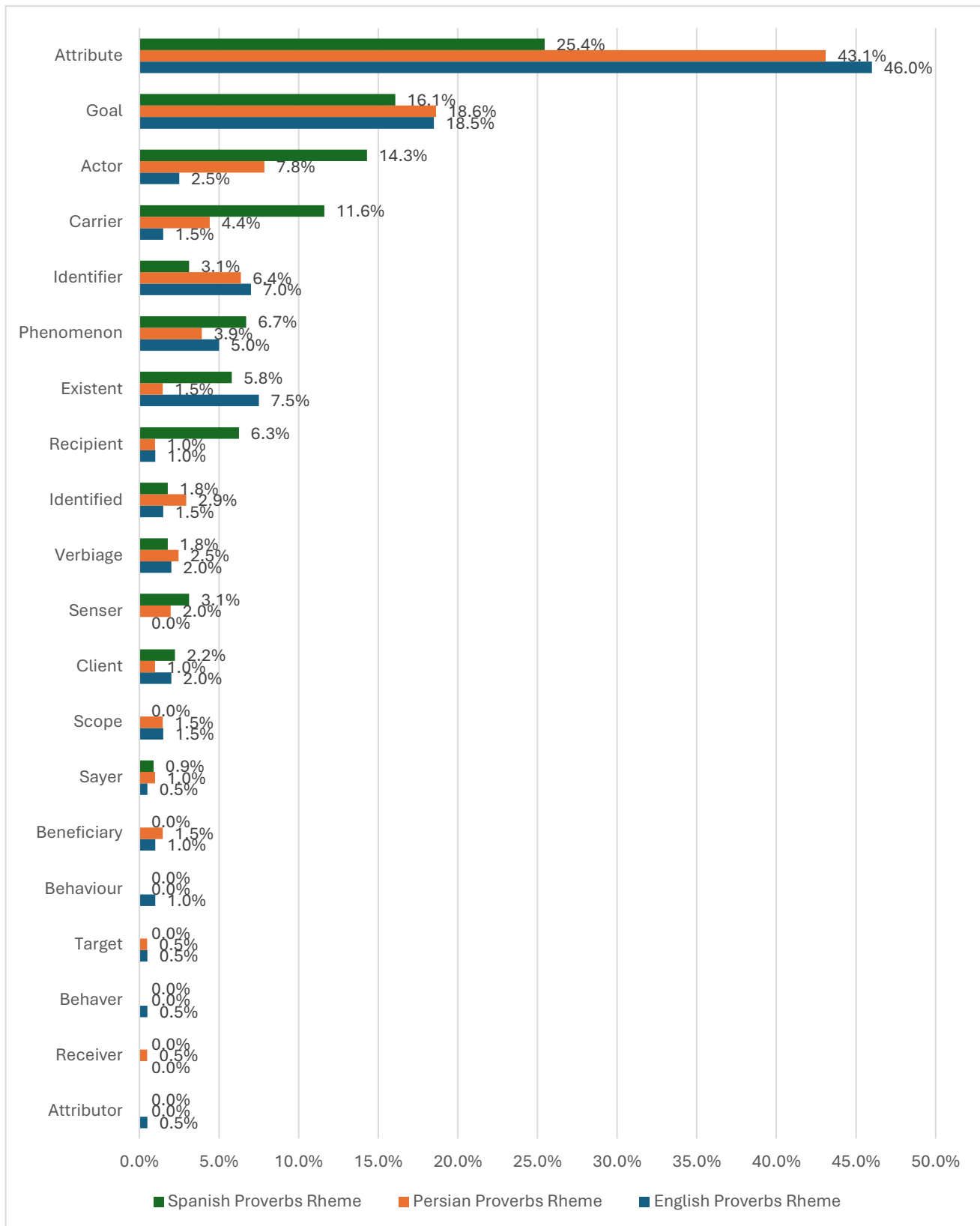


Fig. 9 Comparative ratio of the participant types in Rheme across the three languages

Table 11 shows a comparative analysis of the frequency and the relative frequency of participant types. Across all three languages, the analysis of participants in the Theme showed that Carrier was the most frequent participant in both the English (45.6%, N = 98) and Persian (39.5%, N = 96) corpora, whereas in the Spanish corpus it was Actor (37.5%, N = 72). The second most dominant participant was Actor both in English (30.2%, N = 65) and Persian (23.9%, N = 58), while in the Spanish corpus, the second place was taken by Carrier (24.5%, N = 47). The results indicated that the third most frequent participant in the Theme was Identified (6.5%, N = 14) in the English corpus, Goal (13.6%, N = 33) in the Persian corpus, and Attribute (9.9%, N = 19) in the Spanish corpus. The fourth most dominant participant was Goal (6%, N = 13) in English, Identified (5.8%, N = 14) in Persian, and Recipient (5.2%, N = 10) in Spanish. The results showed no instance of some of the participants in the English corpus, namely Scope, Recipient, Behaver, Behaviour, Verbiage, Target, Attributor, Inducer, and Beneficiary. In the Persian corpus, Client, Behaviour, Receiver, Target, Attributor, and Inducer were absent, and, in the Spanish corpus, Target, Scope, Client, Behavior, Receiver, Attributor and Existent did not appear in the Theme.

Regarding the analysis of Rheme, the results showed that Attribute and Goal were the first two most dominant participants across the three corpora. The highest ratio for Attribute was in English (46%, N = 92), then Persian (43.1%, N = 88), and finally Spanish (25.4%, N = 57). For Goal, the ratio was very close in English (18.5%, N = 37), Persian (18.6%, N = 38), and Spanish (16.1%, N = 36). The third most frequent participant in the Rheme was shared between the Persian (7.8%, N = 16) and Spanish (14.3%, N = 32) corpora, namely, Actor, while in the English corpus, this participant was Existent (7.5%, N = 15). The results showed that English and Persian shared the fourth most dominant participant type in the Rheme, namely Identifier (7%, N = 14, in English, and 6.4%, N = 13, in Persian), while the fourth place in Spanish was occupied by Carrier (11.6%, N = 26). The results showed that some participants were not used in the Rheme of the clauses. In the English corpus, these were Senser, Receiver, and Inducer, and in the Persian corpus, they were Behaver, Attributor, and Inducer. Finally, the results showed that, in the Spanish corpus, Scope, Behaviour, Behavior, Receiver, Target, Inducer, Beneficiary, and Attributor were absent from the Rheme.

	English Proverbs		Persian Proverbs		Spanish Proverbs		Total Items	Total
Participant Types	Theme	Rheme	Theme	Rheme	Theme	Rheme	Theme	Rheme
Carrier	98 45.6%	3 1.5%	96 39.5%	9 4.4%	47 24.5%	26 11.6%	241 37%	38 6%
Attribute	2 0.9%	92 46%	6 2.5%	88 43.1%	19 9.9%	57 25.4%	27 4.1%	237 37.8%
Actor	65 30.2%	5 2.5%	58 23.9%	16 7.8%	72 37.5%	32 14.3%	195 29.9%	53 8.4%
Goal	13 6%	37 18.5%	33 13.6%	38 18.6%	7 3.6%	36 16.1%	53 8.1%	111 17.7%
Identified	14 6.5%	3 1.5%	14 5.8%	6 2.9%	7 3.6%	4 1.8%	35 5.3%	13 2%
Phenomenon	2 0.9%	10 5.0%	5 2.1%	8 3.9%	7 3.6%	15 6.7%	14 2.1%	33 5.2%
Identifier	2 0.9%	14 7.0%	6 2.5%	13 6.4%	2 1%	7 3.1%	10 1.5%	34 5.4%
Existent	1 0.5%	15 7.5%	8 3.3%	3 1.5%	0 0%	13 5.8%	9 1.3%	31 4.9%
Senser	10 4.7%	0 0%	6 2.5%	4 2.0%	9 4.7%	7 3.1%	25 3.8%	11 1.7%
Recipient	0 0%	2 1.0%	0 0.0%	2 1.0%	10 5.2%	14 6.3%	10 1.5%	18 2.8%
Sayer	6 2.8%	1 0.5%	5 2.1%	2 1.0%	7 3.6%	2 0.9%	18 2.7%	5 0.7%
Verbiage	0 0%	4 2.0%	1 0.4%	5 2.5%	1 0.5%	4 1.8%	2 0.3%	13 2%
Client	1 0.5%	4 2%	0 0%	2 1.0%	0 0%	5 2.2%	1 0.1%	11 1.7%
Beneficiary	0 0%	2 1.0%	2 0.8%	3 1.5%	2 1%	0 0%	4 0.6%	5 0.7%
Scope	0 0%	3 1.5%	1 0.4%	3 1.5%	0 0%	0 0%	1 0.1%	6 0.9%
Behaver	0 0%	1 0.5%	1 0.4%	0 0.0%	3 1.5%	0 0.0%	4 0.6%	1 0.1%
Behaviour	0 0%	2 1.0%	0 0.0%	1 0.5%	0 0%	0 0%	0 0%	2 0.3%
Target	0 0%	1 0.5%	0 0%	1 0.5%	0 0%	0 0%	0 0%	2 0.3%
Receiver	1 0.5%	0 0%	0 0%	1 0.5%	0 0%	0 0%	1 0.1%	1 0.1%
Attributor	0 0%	1 0.5%	0 0%	0 0%	0 0%	0 0%	0 0%	1 0.1%
Inducer	0	0	0	0	1	0	1	0

	0%	0%	0%	0%	0.5%	0%	0.1%	0%
Total	215	200	242	204	194	222	651	626
	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%

Table 11 Comparative relative frequency of the participant types in Theme and Rheme across the three languages

The quantitative comparison between Theme and Rheme positions reveals clear differences in the distribution of participant types, suggesting functional distinctions between the two. In the Theme, participants such as the Carrier and Actor dominate, indicating a focus on entities that are either the topic of identification or agents of action. In contrast, the Rheme is characterized by a greater presence of the Attribute and Goal, reflecting its role in introducing new or elaborate information. The Actor appears less frequently in the Rheme, while participants like the Identified and Phenomenon are more prominent. Additionally, the Rheme includes a broader range of participant types, such as the Sayer and Recipient, which are marginal or absent in the Theme. These patterns indicate that the thematic position tends to foreground known or agentive elements, while the rhematic position introduces new or descriptive information.

A Chi-Square test of independence revealed a significant association between languages and participant types in the Theme of the proverbs, rejecting the null hypothesis. The overall Chi-Square value ($\chi^2 = 905.83$) exceeded the critical value ($\chi^2 = 55.76$, $df = 40$, $\alpha = 0.05$), confirming the relationship. Pairwise comparisons also showed significance: English–Persian ($\chi^2 = 55.40$), Persian–Spanish ($\chi^2 = 91.08$), and English–Spanish ($\chi^2 = 86.46$), each surpassing the critical value of 31.41. Thus, language and participant type are statistically linked in this context.

The Chi-Square test of independence showed a significant association between languages and participant types in the Rheme of the proverbs, rejecting the null hypothesis. The overall Chi-Square value ($\chi^2 = 109.60$) exceeded the critical value ($\chi^2 = 55.76$, $df = 40$, $\alpha = 0.05$). Pairwise comparisons also confirmed significance: English–Persian ($\chi^2 = 52.40$), Persian–Spanish ($\chi^2 = 69.39$), and English–Spanish ($\chi^2 = 86.66$), each surpassing the critical value of 31.41. Thus, a relationship exists between language and participant type in the Rheme.

3.3 Circumstance

Circumstance is the third element of the TRANSITIVITY system in the SFG. This term makes reference to the situation or the state in which the process and the participant(s) are involved. 9 types of circumstance are found in this study, including: location, manner, matter, cause, accompaniment, contingency, extent, role, and angle. As in the previous sections, in each

example, the circumstance appearing in the Theme and the Rheme will be presented in italics, and the specific type of circumstance will be indicated in parentheses at the end of the proverb.

3.3.1 English

The results of the analysis indicated that only four circumstance types were found in the Theme position of the English corpus, namely location, contingency, manner, and cause. In contrast, a greater variety of circumstance types was observed in the Rheme position, including location, manner, matter, accompaniment, cause, extent, role, and contingency. Some examples of circumstances occurring in both the Theme and Rheme positions are presented below:

- (130) *After a storm* comes a calm. (Location in Theme)
- (131) *If you can't beat them*, join them. (Contingency in Theme)
- (132) *As you make your bed* you must lie on it. (Manner in Theme)
- (133) *For mad words* deaf ears. (Cause in Theme)
- (134) All rivers run *into the sea*. (Location in Rheme)
- (135) Man does not live *by bread alone*. (Manner in Rheme)
- (136) Men are blind *in their own case*. (Matter in Rheme)
- (137) Don't play *with edged tools*. (Accompaniment in Rheme)
- (138) Sometimes one can't see the woods *for the trees*. (Cause in Rheme)
- (139) Fortune knocks *once* at every man's door. (Extent in Rheme)
- (140) When in Rome do *as the Romans do*. (Role in Rheme)
- (141) There are remedies for everything *but death*. (Contingency in Rheme)

Based on the results in Figure 11, location (N = 16), contingency (N = 6), manner (N = 4), and cause (N = 1) were the only circumstance types to appear in the Theme of the English corpus. There seemed to be a tendency in the English corpus for circumstance types to be more concentrated in the Rheme of the clause. These circumstances were as follows: location (N = 37), manner (N = 16), matter (N = 13), cause (N = 6), accompaniment (N = 7), extent (N = 4), role (N = 3), and contingency (N = 1):

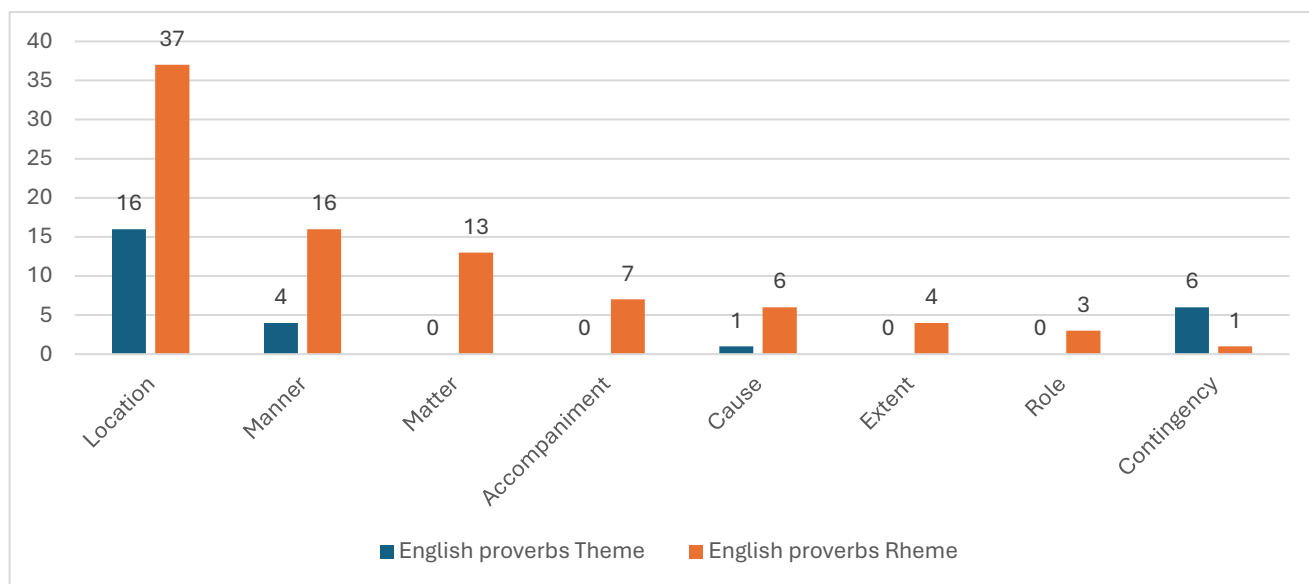


Fig. 10 Frequency of the circumstance types in Theme and Rheme in the English proverbs

As Table 12 shows, the relative frequency of the most dominant circumstance types in the Theme of the English corpus was as follows: location (59.2%), contingency (22.2%), manner (14.8%), and cause (3.7%). Regarding the circumstance types in the Rheme, the order does not remain the same for the first two types, which are followed by additional circumstance types: location (42.5%), manner (18.3%), matter (14.9%), accompaniment (8.0%), cause (6.8%), extent (4.5%), role (3.4%), and contingency (1.1%):

English proverbs					
Circumstance Types	Theme	Percentage	Circumstance Types	Rheme	Percentage
Location	16	59.2%	Location	37	42.5%
Contingency	6	22.2%	Manner	16	18.3%
Manner	4	14.8%	Matter	13	14.9%
Cause	1	3.7%	Accompaniment	7	8.0%
Accompaniment	0	0%	Cause	6	6.8%
Extent	0	0%	Extent	4	4.5%
Matter	0	0%	Role	3	3.4%
Role	0	0%	Contingency	1	1.1%
Total	27	100.00%	Total	87	100.00%

Table 12 Relative frequency of the circumstance types in Theme and Rheme in the English proverbs

3.3.2 Persian

In the Persian corpus, various types of circumstances were identified in both the Theme and the Rheme. The circumstance types found in the Theme included location, matter, cause, manner, extent, and accompaniment, while in the Rheme, the same types were present with the addition of role. The following examples illustrate these occurrences:

از پی دشمن گریخته نباید رفت.

- (142) *Az peye doshmane gorikhteh nabaayad raft.*
 behind enemy escaped NEG.should go.PRS.3SG.S

‘One should not go behind an escaped enemy.’ (Lit. ‘Behind enemy escaped should not go.’) (Location in Theme)

آنقدر ثمن است که یاسمن توش گم است.

- (143) *Aanghadr saman ast ke yasaman*
 so.many jasmine.small exist.PRS.3SG.S that jasmine.big
 toosh gom ast.
 inside lost be.PRS.3SG.S

‘There are so many little jasmine plants that the biggest one is not seen.’ (Lit. ‘So many little jasmines are that the biggest jasmine inside lost is.’) (Cause in Theme)

اگر لری به بازار نرود، بازار می گندد.

- (144) *Agar Lor be bazaar naravad baazaar migandad.*
 if Luri to bazaar NEG.go.PRS.SBJV.3SG.S bazaar spoil.PRS.3SG.S

‘If Luri doesn’t go to bazaar, bazaar spoils.’ (Lit. ‘If Lor to bazaar doesn’t go, bazaar spoils.’) (Contingency in Theme)

اسب نجیب را یک تازیانه بس است.

- (145) *Asbe najib raa⁷ yek tazyaneh bas ast.*
 horse submissive DOM one whip enough be.PRS.3SG.S

‘One whip is enough for a submissive horse.’ (Lit. ‘Horse submissive concerning one whip enough is.’) (Matter in Theme)

بازی بازی آخرش جدی می شود.

- (146) *Baazi baazi aakharesh jeddi mishavad.*
 playfully playfully 3.POSS.end serious become.PRS.3SG.S

‘In play, it ends seriously.’ (Lit. ‘Playfully playfully its end serious becomes.’) (Manner in Theme)

با آنکه خصومت نتوان کرد بساز.

⁷ Please note that *raa*, which generally represents a DOM (Direct Object Marker) in Persian, means ‘concerning’ in this example.

- (147) *Baa aanke khosoomat natavaan kard besaaz.*

with whom enmity NEG.can do get.along.PRS.3SG.S

‘You must get along with whoever you can’t be an enemy to.’ (Lit. ‘With whom enmity can’t be done, get along.’) (Accompaniment in Theme)

گاه باشد که کودکی نادان به خطا بر هدف زند تیری.

- (148) *Gaah baashad ke koodaki nadaan*

sometimes be.SBJV.3SG.S that child ignorant

be khataa bar hadaf zanad tiri.

by mistake to target hit.PRS.3SG.S arrow

‘Sometimes a simple child might hit the target by chance.’ (Lit. ‘Sometimes be that a child ignorant by mistake to target hit an arrow.’) (Extent in Theme)

باز گردد به اصل خود هر چیز.

- (149) *Baaz gardad be asle khod harchiz.*

back go.PRS.3SG.S to origin.of 3SG.REFL everything

‘Everything goes back to its origin.’ (Lit. ‘Back goes to origin of itself everything.’) (Location in Rheme)

عالم بی عمل مثل زنبور بی عسل است.

- (150) *Aaleme biamal mesle zanboore biasal ast*

scholar.of deedless like bee.of honeyless be.PRS.3SG.S

‘A deedless scholar is like a honeyless bee.’ (Lit. ‘Scholar deedless like bee of honeyless is.’) (Manner in Rheme)

میهمان تا سه روز عزیز است.

- (151) *Mihmaan taa se rooz aziz ast.*

guest till three day dear be.PRS.3SG.S

‘A guest is dear up to three days.’ (Lit. ‘Guest till three days dear is.’) (Extent in Rheme)

رنگ رخساره خیر می دهد از سر ضمیر.

- (152) *Range rokhsaareh khabar midahad az serre zamir.*

colour.of face report do.PRS.3SG.S about secret.of inside

‘The colour of the face reveals an inner secret.’ (Lit. ‘Colour of face report does about secret of inside.’) (Matter in Rheme)

پهلوان از پیرفنی به زمین می خورد.

- (153) Pahlavaan az por fanni be zamin mikhorad.
 champion of full experience to floor fall.PRS.3SG.S
 ‘The champion goes down because of excessive skill.’ (Lit. ‘Champion of full experience to floor falls.’) (Cause in Rheme)

زمانه با تو نسازد تو با زمانه بساز.

- (154) Zamaaneh baa to nasaazad to baa
 destiny with you NEG.get.along.PRS.SBJV.3SG.S you with
 zamaaneh besaaz.
 destiny get.along.IMP.2SG.S
 ‘If destiny does not get along with you, you must get along with it.’ (Lit. ‘Destiny with you does not get along, you with destiny get along.’) (Accompaniment in Rheme)

ابرو گشاده باش اگر دستت گشاده نیست.

- (155) Abroogoshaadeh baash agar dastat goshaadeh
 openbrowed be.IMP.2SG.S if hand.2.POSS.SG open
 nist.
 NEG be.PRS.3SG.S
 ‘Be open-browed if you are not wealthy.’ (Lit. ‘Open-browed be if your hand is not open.’) (Contingency in Rheme)

جهنم به آن گرمی هم که می گویند نیست.

- (156) Jahannam be aan garmi ham ke migooyand nist.
 hell to that warm so that say.PRS.3PL.S NEG.be.PRS.3SG.S
 ‘Hell is not as warm as they say.’ (Lit. ‘Hell as that warm that (they) say is not.’) (Role in Rheme)

The results for the Persian corpus (Figure 12) showed a similar distribution of circumstance types along the Theme and the Rheme of the clauses. The analysis of Theme showed the following circumstance types in descending order: location (N = 24), cause (N = 16), contingency (N = 14), matter (N = 8), manner (N = 5), accompaniment (N = 2), and extent (N = 1). However, role did not occur in the Theme of the Persian corpus. The circumstance types in Rheme were as follows: location

(N = 51), manner (N = 14), extent (N = 8), matter (N = 5), cause (N = 5), accompaniment (N = 5), contingency (N = 3), and role (N = 2):

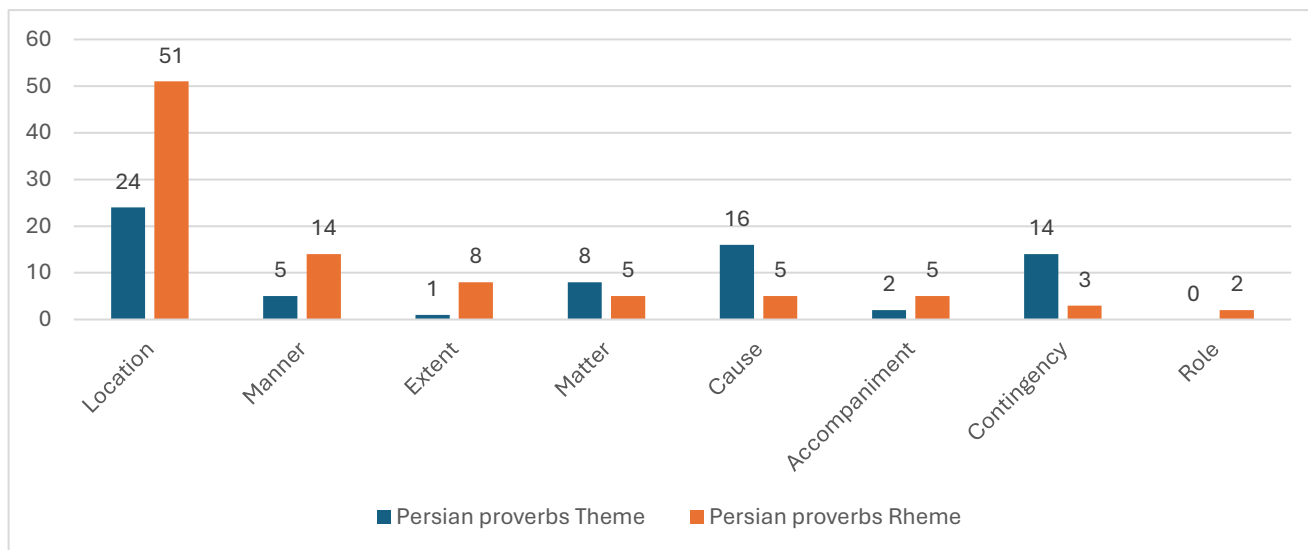


Fig. 11 Frequency of the circumstance types in Theme and Rheme in the Persian proverbs

The same results (Table 13) in terms of relative frequency showed the following order of the most frequent circumstance types in the Theme of the Persian corpus: location (34.2%), cause (22.8%), matter (11.4%), manner (7.1%), accompaniment (2.8%), and extent (1.4%). In the Rheme, this order was: location (54.8%), manner (15%), extent (8.6%), matter, cause, and accompaniment (5.3%), contingency (3.2%), and role (2.1%):

Persian proverbs					
Circumstance Types	Theme	Percentage	Circumstance Types	Rheme	Percentage
Location	24	34.2%	Location	51	54.8%
Cause	16	22.8%	Manner	14	15.0%
Contingency	14	20%	Extent	8	8.6%
Matter	8	11.4%	Matter	5	5.3%
Manner	5	7.1%	Cause	5	5.3%
Accompaniment	2	2.8%	Accompaniment	5	5.3%
Extent	1	1.4%	Contingency	3	3.2%
Role	0	0%	Role	2	2.1%
Total	70	100%	Total	93	100%

Table 13 Relative frequency of the circumstance types in Theme and Rheme in the Persian proverbs

3.3.3 Spanish

A range of circumstance types were identified in both the Theme and the Rheme within the Spanish corpus. These circumstance types include location, cause, manner, matter, contingency, extent, accompaniment, angle, and role. Examples of these circumstance types in the Spanish corpus are provided as follows:

- (157) *A la olla que hierve ninguna mosca*
 to the pot that boil.PRS.3SG.S no fly
 se atreve.

REFL dare.PRS.3SG.S

‘No fly dares to get close to a boiling pot.’ (Lit. ‘To the pot that boils no fly dares.’) (Location in Theme)

- (158) *Por sus frutos los conoceréis.*
 of 3.POSS.PL fruit.PL them know.FUT.2PL.S

‘You will recognize them by their deeds.’ (Lit. ‘Of their fruits they know you.’) (Cause in Theme)

- (159) *Ante la duda, abstente.*
 before the doubt abstain.IMP.2SG.S.REFL

‘When in doubt, abstain.’ (Lit. ‘Before the doubt, abstain yourself.’) (Contingency in Theme)

- (160) *Como siembras recogerás.*
 as sow.PRS.2SG.S reap.FUT.2SG.S

‘As you sow, you reap.’ (Lit. ‘As you sow, you will reap.’) (Manner in Theme)

- (161) *Sobre gustos no hay nada escrito.*
 about taste.PL not there.be.PRS.3SG.S nothing write.PTCP

‘There is no rule for taste.’ (Lit. ‘About tastes there is not nothing written.’) (Matter in Theme)

- (162) *Siempre sale a hablar quien tiene*
 always go.out.PRS.3SG.S to speak who has.PRS.3SG.S
 por qué callar.
 for why shut.up.INF

‘The one who should be silent always speaks.’ (Lit. ‘Always goes to speak who has for why shut up.’) (Extent in Theme)

- (163) *Con paciencia todo se logra.*
 with patience all REFL achieve.PRS.3SG.S

‘With patience everything is achieved.’ (Lit. ‘With patience all is achieved.’) (Accompaniment in Theme)

- (164) *Al escarabajo sus hijos le parecen*
 to beetle 3.POSS.PL children him seem.PRS.3PL.S
granos de oro.
 grain.PL of gold

‘Beetle’s children seem to him like gold particles.’ (Lit. ‘To the beetle his children him seem grains of gold.’)

(Angle in Theme)

- (165) *Cada uno en su casa es rey.*
 every one in 3.POSS.SG house be.PRS.3SG.S king

‘Everyone feels like a king in his own house.’ (Lit. ‘Every one in his house is king.’) (Location in Rheme)

- (166) *No se ganó Zamora en una hora.*
 not REFL win.PST.3SG.S Zamora in one hour

‘Zamora was not conquered in one hour.’ (Lit. ‘Not won Zamora in one hour.’) (Extent in Rheme)

- (167) *Aquel va más sano que anda*
 that go.PRS.3SG.S more healthy that walk.PRS.3SG.S
por lo llano.
 on the plain

‘The one who walks on the plain goes more safely.’ (Lit. ‘He goes more safely that walks on the plain.’)

(Manner in Rheme)

- (168) *Desnudan a un santo para vestir a otro.*
 strip.PRS.3PL.S to a saint for dress.INF to another

‘They strip one saint to dress another.’ (Lit. ‘Strip they of a saint for dressing of other.’) (Cause in Rheme)

- (169) *No te acostarás sin saber una cosa más.*
 not REFL go.to.bed.FUT.2SG.S without know.INF one thing more

‘Don’t go to sleep without learning a new thing.’ (Lit. ‘You won’t go to bed without knowing one thing more.’)

(Accompaniment in Rheme)

- (170) *El águila no se entretiene en cazar moscas*
 the eagle not REFL entertain.PRS.3SG.S in hunt.INF fly.PL

‘The eagle does not bother to hunt flies.’ (Lit. ‘The eagle not himself entertain in hunting flies.’) (Matter in Rheme)

- (171) No hay cerradura segura si es
 not there.be.PRS.3SG.S lock safe if be.PRS.3SG.O
de oro la ganzúa.
 of gold the lockpick

‘There is no lock that is safe if the lockpick is made of gold.’ (Lit. ‘Not there is lock safe if is of gold the lockpick.’) (Contingency in Rheme)

- (172) No es tan bravo el león como lo pintan.
 not be.PRS.3SG.S so brave the lion as the paint.PRS.3PL.S

‘The lion is not as brave as they paint him.’ (Lit. ‘Not is so brave the lion as the they paint him.’) (Role in Rheme)

The results of the analysis for the Spanish corpus showed (Figure 13) the occurrence of various circumstance types along the Theme and the Rheme of the proverbs. The frequency of the circumstance types that appeared in the Theme of the clauses was as follows: location (N = 32), cause (N = 19), contingency (N = 7), manner and matter (N = 6), extent (N = 2), accompaniment and angle (N = 1). Circumstances of role did not occur at all in the analysis of Theme in the Spanish proverbs. Surprisingly, the proportion of circumstances in the Rheme analysis turned out to be close to that in the Theme: location (N = 33), extent (N = 11), manner (N = 10), cause (N = 9), accompaniment (N = 6), matter (N = 3), contingency (N = 3), and role (N = 1):

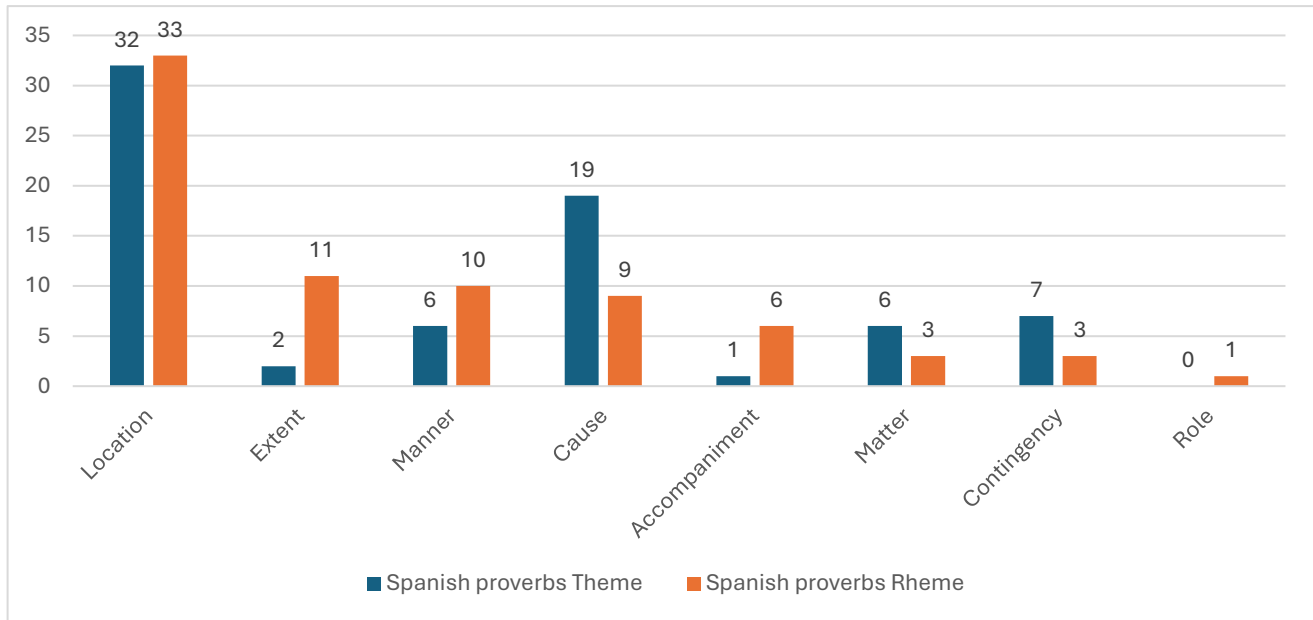


Fig. 12 Frequency of the circumstance types in Theme and Rheme in the Spanish proverbs

As Table 14 shows, the relative frequencies of the results from the Theme analysis for the Spanish corpus revealed that the most dominant circumstances in the Theme were: location (43.2%), cause (25.6%), contingency (9.4%), manner (8.1%), matter (8.1%), extent (2.7%), accompaniment (1.3%), and angle (1.3%). Notably, the only circumstance type that did not appear in the Theme of this corpus was role. Surprisingly, the proportion of circumstance types in the Rheme analysis closely mirrored that found in the Theme: location (43.4%), extent (14.4%), manner (13.1%), cause (11.8%), accompaniment (7.8%), matter (3.9%), contingency (3.9%), and role (1.3%):

Spanish Proverbs					
Circumstance Types	Theme	Percentage	Circumstance Types	Rheme	Percentage
Location	32	43.2%	Location	33	43.4%
Cause	19	25.6%	Extent	11	14.4%
Contingency	7	9.4%	Manner	10	13.1%
Manner	6	8.1%	Cause	9	11.8%
Matter	6	8.1%	Accompaniment	6	7.8%
Extent	2	2.7%	Matter	3	3.9%
Accompaniment	1	1.3%	Contingency	3	3.9%
Angle	1	1.3%	Role	1	1.3%
Role	0	0.0%	Angle	0	0.0%
Total	74	100.00%	Total	76	100.00%

Table 14 Relative frequency of the circumstance types in Theme and Rheme in the Spanish proverbs

3.3.4 Quantitative cross-language analysis

Figures 14 and 15 provide a summary of the relative frequency of the circumstance types occurring in both the Theme and the Rheme across the three corpora. As regards the Theme (Figure 14), if we compare the circumstance types in the Theme of all three corpora in terms of relative frequency, location was the most frequent in all three (59.2%, 34.2%, and 43.2% in English, Persian, and Spanish respectively). Regarding the remaining circumstance types, there were only three more types in the Theme of the English corpus: contingency (22.2%), manner (14.8%) and cause (3.7%). In the Persian corpus, the most frequent circumstance types were as follows: cause (22.8%), contingency (20%), matter (11.8%), manner (7.1%), accompaniment (2.8%) and extent (1.4%). The analysis of Theme for the Spanish corpus showed the following circumstance types: cause (25.6%), contingency (9.4%), manner and matter (8.1%), extent (2.7%), accompaniment, and angle (1.3%) consecutively.

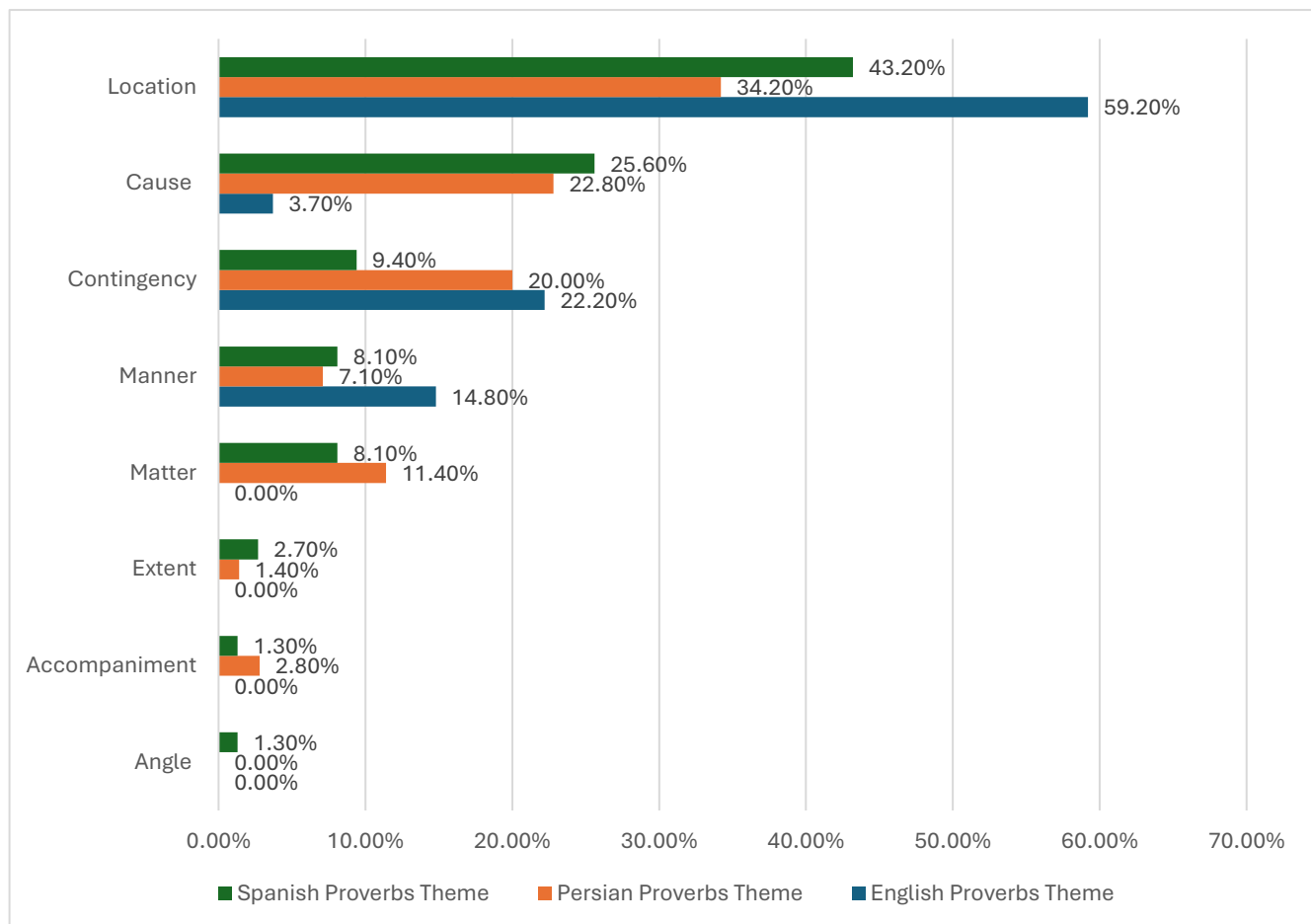


Fig. 13 Comparative ratio of the circumstance types in Theme across the three languages

With respect to the Rheme (Figure 15), the results of the analysis of Rheme revealed that the first and second circumstance types were shared across the three languages, namely location (42.5% in English, 54.8% in Persian, and 43.4%

in Spanish) and manner only for the English and Persian corpora (18.3% in English, 15% in Persian). In Spanish, the second place was occupied by extent (14.4%). In English, the remaining circumstance types were: matter (14.9%), accompaniment (8%), cause (6.8%), extent (4.5%), role (3.4%), and contingency (1.1%). The order of the circumstance types in the Persian corpus was: extent (8.6%), cause, matter and accompaniment (5.3%), contingency (3.2%), and role (2.2%) and, for the Spanish, it was: manner (13.1%), cause (11.8%), accompaniment (7.8%), matter and contingency (3.9%), and role (1.3%).

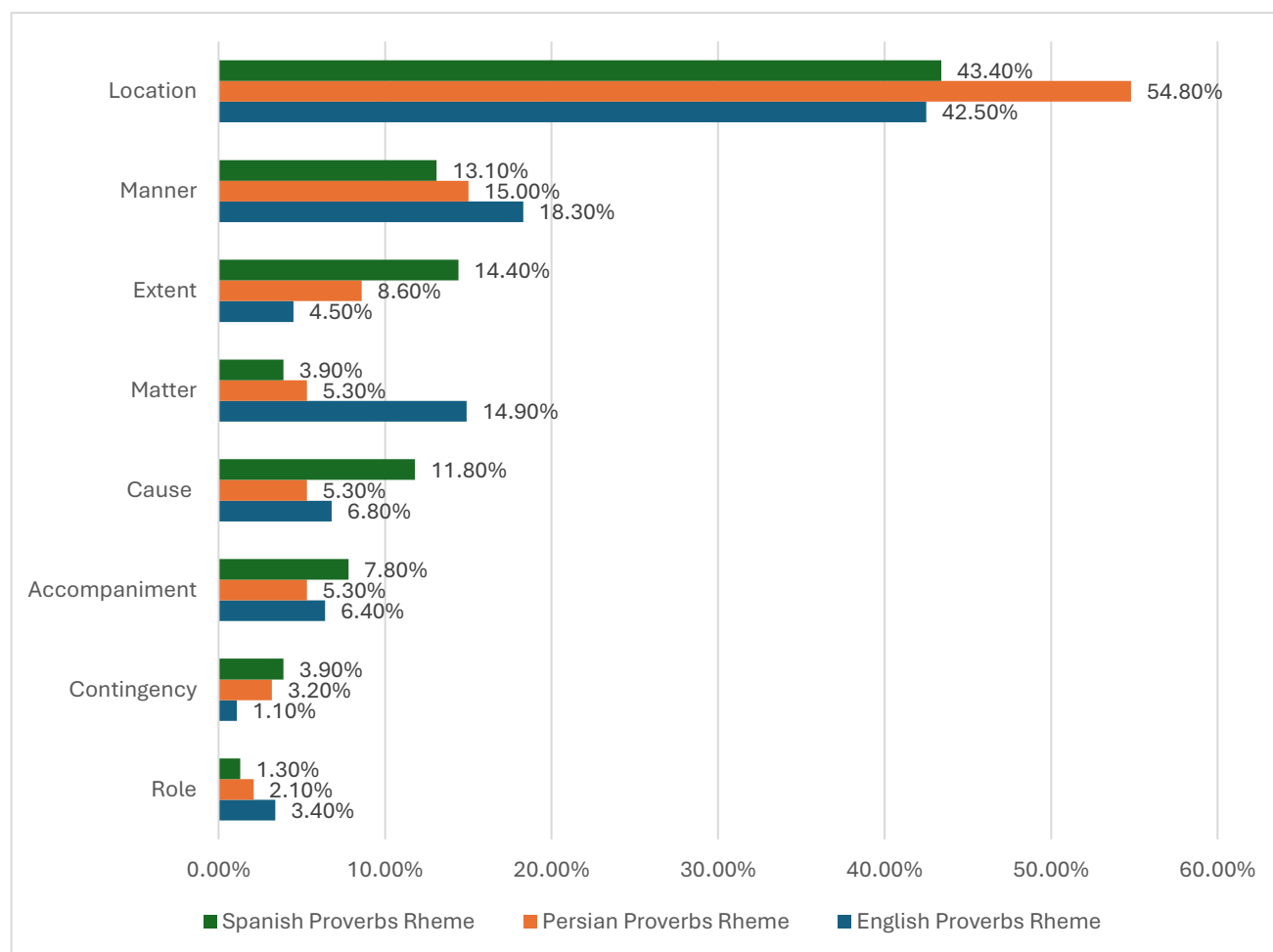


Fig. 14 Comparative ratio of the circumstance types in Rheme across the three languages

Based on Table 15, the trilingual analysis of circumstance in the Theme showed that location was the most frequent circumstance (59.2%, N = 16, 34.2%, N = 24, and 43.2%, N = 32, in English, Persian, and Spanish, respectively). However, from the second most dominant circumstance onwards, the three corpora do not resemble one another. The second most frequently encountered circumstance (cause) appeared to be shared by both Persian (22.8%, N = 16) and Spanish (25.6%, N = 19), but did not feature in English, where second place was occupied by contingency (22.2%, N = 6). The third most frequently observed circumstance (contingency) was also shared only between Persian (20%, N = 14) and Spanish (9.4%, N = 7), while in English the third place was occupied by manner (14.8%, N = 4). In English, the fourth place was occupied by

cause (3.7%, N =1), while in Persian matter (11.45%, N =8) and in Spanish, both matter and manner scored as the fourth common circumstances (8.1%, N = 6). Since only four types of circumstance existed in the English corpus, the following deals with the Persian and Spanish. The circumstance types in fifth, sixth, and seventh place in the Persian corpus were manner (7.1%, N = 5), accompaniment (2.8%, N = 2), and extent (1.4%, N = 1), whereas in the Spanish corpus, the order was as follows: extent (2.7%, N = 2), accompaniment (1.3%, N = 1), and angle (1.3%, N = 1).

As regards the analysis of the frequency of circumstance types in the Rheme, after location, which was the most frequent circumstance type in all three corpora (42.5%, N = 37, 54.8%, N = 51, and 43.4%, N = 33, in English, Persian, and Spanish, respectively), the second, manner, was only shared by English (18.3%, N =16) and Persian (15%, N = 14), while the second place in Spanish was occupied by extent (14.4%, N = 11). The third most frequent circumstance type was matter (14.9%, N = 13), extent (8.6%, N = 8), and manner (13.1%, N = 10) in English, Persian and Spanish, respectively. The fourth most dominant circumstance types were accompaniment (8%, N = 7) in English (6.4%, N = 6), cause, matter and accompaniment in Persian (5.3%, N =5) with cause (11.8%, N = 9) in Spanish. The order for the remaining circumstance types in the English corpus was as follows: cause (6.8%, N =6), extent (4.5%, N = 4), role (3.4%, N = 3), and contingency (1.1%, N = 1). In the Persian corpus, the order was contingency (3.2%, N = 3) followed by role (2.1%, N = 2), and for the Spanish corpus, it was: accompaniment (7.8%, N =6), matter and contingency (3.9%, N = 3), and role (1.3%, N = 1).

	English Proverbs		Persian Proverbs		Spanish Proverbs		Total Items	Total
Circumstance Types	Theme	Rheme	Theme	Rheme	Theme	Rheme	Theme	Rheme
Location	16 59.2%	37 42.5%	24 34.2%	51 54.8%	32 43.2%	33 43.4%	72 42.1%	121 47.2%
Cause	1 3.7%	6 6.8%	16 22.8%	5 5.3%	19 25.6%	9 11.8%	36 21.0%	20 7.8%
Manner	4 14.8%	16 18.3%	5 7.1%	14 15.0%	6 8.1%	10 13.1%	15 8.7%	40 15.6%
Matter	0 0.0%	13 14.9%	8 11.4%	5 5.3%	6 8.1%	3 3.9%	14 8.1%	21 8.2%
Contingency	6 22.2%	1 1.1%	14 20.0%	3 3.2%	7 9.4%	3 3.9%	27 15.7%	7 2.7%
Extent	0 0.0%	4 4.5%	1 1.4%	8 8.6%	2 2.7%	11 14.4%	3 1.7%	23 8.9%
Accompaniment	0 0.0%	7 8.0%	2 2.8%	5 5.3%	1 1.3%	6 7.8%	3 1.7%	18 7.0%
Role	0 0.0%	3 3.4%	0 0.0%	2 2.1%	0 0.0%	1 1.3%	0 0%	6 2.3%
Angle	0 0.0%	0 0.0%	0 0.0%	0 0.0%	1 1.3%	0 0.0%	1 0.5%	0 0%
Total	27 100%	87 100%	70 100%	93 100%	74 100%	76 100%	171 100%	256 100%

Table 15 Comparative relative frequency of the circumstance types in Theme and Rheme across the three languages

Although location was the most frequent circumstance type in both the Theme and the Rheme across all three corpora, the corpora exhibited more similarity in the Rheme than in the Theme, due to the greater variety of circumstance types that appeared there, with manner being the second most frequent circumstance in English and Persian. The absence of role in Theme and angle in Rheme was a commonality across the three languages. However, an important distinction was observed: in the English corpus, only four types of circumstance appeared in the Theme – location, cause, contingency and manner – whereas the Persian corpus also included matter, extent, and accompaniment, and the Spanish corpus featured these, as well as angle. These results suggest that language-specific preferences shape the distribution of circumstantial meanings, particularly in clause-initial positions.

The Chi-Square test showed no significant relationship between languages and circumstance types in the Theme of the proverbs, as the overall value ($\chi^2 = 18.90$) was below the critical threshold ($\chi^2 = 26.30$, $df = 16$, $\alpha = 0.05$). Pairwise comparisons also confirmed no association: English–Persian ($\chi^2 = 14.86$), English–Spanish ($\chi^2 = 14.91$), and Persian–Spanish

($\chi^2 = 8.03$), all below the critical value of 15.51. Therefore, no statistical link was found between language and circumstance type in this context.

The Chi-Square test showed no significant relationship between languages and circumstance types in the Rheme of the proverbs, as the overall value ($\chi^2 = 20.70$) was below the critical threshold ($\chi^2 = 26.30$, $df = 16$, $\alpha = 0.05$). Pairwise results confirmed this, except for English–Spanish ($\chi^2 = 17.47 > \chi^2 \text{ critical} = 15.51$), which indicated a relationship. Thus, no association was found between language and circumstance type in the Rheme, except between English and Spanish.

3.3.5 *Summary of the Results of the Analysis of the TRANSITIVITY System in the Theme and Rheme of the Proverbs and Comparison with the Results of Previous Studies*

This section summarizes the analysis of TRANSITIVITY elements in the Theme and Rheme of proverbs across three languages, compared with McCabe's study—the only known parallel. Results show distinct patterns, especially in the Theme: English proverbs predominantly feature material (84.6%) and behavioural (15.3%) processes; Persian proverbs lack processes in the Theme; Spanish proverbs display greater variety, with existential (30.7%) and material (26.9%) processes most frequent, followed by behavioural (11.5%) and several others at lower rates.

However, in the analysis of process types in the Rheme, the results revealed greater homogeneity across the three corpora, particularly between the English and Spanish corpora, and between the Spanish and Persian corpora. Nonetheless, this pattern of similarity was not observed between the English and Persian corpora, indicating a divergence in the distribution of process types in this pair. More specifically, material and relational intensive attributive were the most dominant processes in all three corpora (39.9% and 30.60% in Persian and 46.5% and 26.7% in the Spanish corpus), but this order was reversed for the English corpus in that relational intensive attributive (35.5%) was ahead of material (34.2%), albeit with a slight difference (1.3%). Existential and mental shared third place equally in English (6.1%) and this place went to relational intensive identifying (7%) in Persian, and, finally, to mental (9%) in the Spanish corpus. If we consider all the relational types in one category, the two most dominant process types were relational and material in English (49.6% and 34.2% respectively) and Persian (47.7% and 39.9%) and material and relational in the Spanish corpus (46.5% and 38.5%). The third most frequent process in English was shared equally by mental and Existential (6.1%), with mental (5.8%) in the Persian corpus, and mental (9%) in the Spanish corpus. The order for the remaining process types in the Rheme was as follows: verbal (3.2%) and behavioural (0.4%) in English; existential (3.5%), verbal (2.7%), and behavioural (0.4%) in Persian; and verbal (3.4%) and existential (2.1%) in Spanish.

Secondly, as for the examination of participants in the Theme and Rheme, the results of the analysis of Theme in terms of participant types showed more of a similarity between the Persian and English corpora in that, in the English corpus, the four most dominant participants were: Carrier (45.6%), Actor (30.2%), Identified (6.5%), and Goal (6%), while in the Persian corpus Goal occupied third place, with Identified in fourth so that the order was as follows: Carrier (39.5%), Actor (23.9%), Goal (13.6%), and Identified (5.8%). For the Spanish corpus, the first two places were occupied by Actor (37.5%) and Carrier (24.5%), unlike in English and Persian, followed by Attribute (9.9%) and Recipient (5.2%). The participants, which did not appear in the Theme in the three corpora, were as follows: Scope, Recipient, Behavior, Behaviour, Verbiage, Target, Attributor, Inducer, and Beneficiary in the English corpus; Client, Behaviour, Receiver, Target, Attributor, and Inducer in the Persian corpus, and Target, Scope, client, Behaviour, Receiver, Attributor, and Existent in the Spanish corpus.

The analysis of Rheme in terms of participant types revealed more similarity between Persian and Spanish in that their top three participants were Attribute (43.1% and 25.4%), Goal (18.6% and 16.1%), and Actor (7.8% and 14.3%), respectively. The top three participants in the English corpus were Attribute (46%), Goal (18.5%), and Existent (7.5%). There was a similarity in English and Persian as, in both, fourth place was occupied by Identifier (7% and 6.4%, respectively); this place was occupied by Carrier (11.6%) in Spanish. English and Spanish were similar in that fifth place was occupied by Phenomenon (5% and 6.7%, respectively); in Persian, Carrier (4.4%) occupied the fifth place. In English, sixth place was shared by both Client and verbiage (2%) equally, whereas in Persian it was occupied by Phenomenon (3.9%), and Recipient (6.3%) in Spanish. Identified, Carrier, and Scope (1.5%) were in seventh place in English. Identified (2.9%) was in seventh place in Persian, and Existential (5.8%) in Spanish. All in all, there was a similar trend across all three languages in terms of the first two participants in Rheme, Attribute and Goal, and from the third participant on, a similar trend was sometimes seen by two of the three corpora.

Finally, the results of the analysis of circumstance in the Theme showed a similarity only in terms of location which was the most dominant circumstance (59.2% in English, 34.2% in Persian, and 43.2% in Spanish). Surprisingly, the results showed only four circumstance types in the English corpus: location (59.2%), contingency (22.2%), manner (14.8%), and cause (3.7%). On the other hand, the Persian and Spanish corpora showed more variety of circumstance types, with even more occurring in the Spanish corpus (seven types in the Persian and eight in the Spanish). In the Persian corpus the order was as follows: location (34.2%), cause (22.8%), contingency (20%), matter (11.4%), manner (7.1%), accompaniment (2.8%) and extent (1.4%). In the Spanish it was: location (43.2%), cause (25.6%), contingency (9.4%), manner and matter (8.1%), extent (2.7%), accompaniment and angle (1.3%).

However, the analysis of circumstance types in Rheme revealed no similar trend across all three corpora even though the first most frequent circumstance types were common among them, and the second one only between English and Persian, namely location and manner. As in the analysis of Rheme, location was the most frequent circumstance across all the three corpora (42.5%, 54.8%, and 43.4% in English, Persian, and Spanish, respectively). Manner was in second place with 18.3% in English, 15% in Persian; however, the second place in Spanish was filled with extent (14.4%). Matter (14.9%), extent (8.6%) and manner (13.1%) ranked third in English, Persian and Spanish, respectively. Accompaniment occupied the fourth place in the English (8%), and cause (5.3%) in Persian and Spanish (11.8%) corpora. In Persian corpus, matter and accompaniment ranked equal with cause (5.3%). The circumstance of role (3.4%, 2.1%, and 1.3% in the English, Persian and the Spanish, respectively) and contingency (1.1%, 3.2%, and 3.9% in the English, Persian and Spanish, respectively) appeared less frequently in the three corpora. On the whole, the results of the analysis of Rheme regarding circumstance types did not show a strong similar trend across the three corpora.

Although McCabe's study does not include the analysis of process types within the Rheme, the examination of these elements in the Theme nevertheless provides an insightful point of comparison. Firstly, in McCabe's study (1999), the results reveal more processes in the Theme of the Spanish corpus than in English. She puts this down to the flexibility of the Spanish corpus, which allows a greater use of process in the Theme (6% and 23%, in English and Spanish, respectively).

Secondly, in McCabe's study the two corpora, namely English and Spanish, showed a similar trend with respect to participants in the Theme where Carrier was the most dominant participant in both English (32%) and Spanish (35%), that is, except for Actor which showed less of a similarity across the two languages and was implemented more in the English (18%) than in the Spanish (8%) corpus. More specifically, in her study, the order of the most frequent participants in the English corpus was as follows: Carrier (32%), Actor (18%), Identified (7%), Senser (6%), Existent (6%), Sayer (5%), Goal (5%), Phenomenon (3%), Verbiage (2%), Attribute (2%), Identifier, Beneficiary, Behaver, Target and Receiver (1%). In her Spanish corpus, the most dominant participants were Carrier (35%), Identified and Actor (13%), Sayer (7%), Existent (5%), Senser and Goal (4%), Phenomenon (3%), Attribute (2%), Identifier, Beneficiary, Verbiage, Receiver, Target, and Behaver (1%). With respect to the analysis of participant types in the Rheme, English and Spanish, show certain similarities since Attribute was the most frequently occurring participant in both corpora (30% and 32% respectively). However, her corpus differs from this one in that Existent (3% and 9%) and Verbiage (4.5% and 8%), in English and Spanish, respectively, appeared more frequently in the Spanish corpus. On the other hand, in her study, the English corpus is ahead of the Spanish in terms of Goal (14% and 8%, in English and Spanish, respectively), Actor (8% and 4%, in English and Spanish), and Sensor (4% and 2%, in English and Spanish).

Where circumstance is the Theme, McCabe's results resemble those of the current study in that location is the most dominant type both in her English (12%) and her Spanish (13%) corpora. However, location as the most highly used circumstance in the Theme is the only common point between her study and this one in that in her study, both corpora (English and Spanish) show a similarity; but, in the results of this study, there were no similarities in terms of the circumstance types in the Theme of the three corpora (English, Spanish, and Persian) except for location as the top one. McCabe's results for her analysis of circumstance in the Rheme show that manner (19%) in Spanish was the most frequently encountered, followed by location (16.5%) in the English corpus. However, the analysis of her data show a similar trend in both corpora in terms of cause (7% and 6%, in English and Spanish, respectively), extent (4% and 2%, in English and Spanish), accompaniment (1.5% and 1%, in English and Spanish), contingency (1% and 0.5%, in English and Spanish), and angle (0.5% and 0%, in English and Spanish). Surprisingly, the results of McCabe's study are similar to this study's in that location and manner appear as the two most frequent circumstances in the Rheme in both studies. However, in the Spanish corpus of this study, it was the extent (14.4%) that took the second place, followed by manner (13.1%).

4 Discussion

After presenting the quantitative analysis of the two systems in the preceding sections, this section provides a qualitative analysis of the results obtained, structured around the two research questions formulated in this study:

RQ1. Is the information contained in a sentence organized in a similar manner in equivalent proverbs in different languages?

RQ2. Does an analysis of the grammatical properties of equivalent proverbs in different languages show similarities and differences among those languages?

The discussion presented in this section begins with an analysis of RQ1, addressing the THEME system by considering the distribution of elements from the TRANSITIVITY system within the Theme and Rheme of the clauses in the proverbs. Given RQ2, the results of the quantitative analysis in the previous section are elaborated and discussed qualitatively.

4.1 Discussion of the Distribution of Process Types in Theme and Rheme

This section, along with the next two, examines clause-level information distribution to evaluate H1 and address RQ1 through the analysis of TRANSITIVITY elements—processes, participants, and circumstances—in the Theme and Rheme of proverbs across three languages. In SFG, Theme frames the message with known information, while Rheme elaborates with new content. The analysis reveals distinct language-specific patterns: English proverbs favor material (84.6%) and behavioural (15.3%) processes, reflecting pragmatic tendencies; Spanish proverbs show a broader range, dominated by existential (30.7%) and material (26.9%) processes, suggesting a cultural focus on states and presence; Persian proverbs lack processes in the Theme due to their SOV structure, underscoring structural differences. These results highlight how linguistic and cultural factors shape proverb construction.

The presence of a variety of process types in the Spanish corpus of this study is compatible with the findings of McCabe's study (1999) in which the Spanish corpus implements twice as many processes as the English with respect to Theme due to the flexibility of this corpus. In her study, the processes in the Theme are 18.29% and 6.15%, in Spanish and English, respectively, while in this research, the frequency of process as Theme is 67.08% and 33.54% in Spanish and English, respectively.

The analysis of the Rheme across the three corpora reveals the prominence of relational intensive processes (both attributive and identifying), with some variation in distribution. In the English corpus, relational intensive attributive processes (35.5%) are the most frequent, followed by material processes (34.2%) and mental processes (6.1%). This suggests a focus on character, actions, and thoughts in English proverbs. In the Persian corpus, material (39.9%) and relational intensive attributive processes (30.6%) dominate, with relational intensive identifying processes (7.0%) also significant. This reflects a similar emphasis on both actions and relationships in Persian proverbs. In the Spanish corpus, material processes (46.5%) lead, followed by relational intensive attributive processes (26.7%) and mental processes (9.0%), with a sharper contrast between material and relational processes. This suggests a greater focus on actions, though still highlighting subject attributes. The lesser frequency of verbal (3.4%) and existential (2.1%) processes emphasizes the prioritization of material and relational processes in Spanish proverbs.

In summary, the analysis of process types in the Theme and Rheme positions of the proverbs across the three languages reveals notable differences in frequency and distribution. Material processes are the most frequent overall, appearing in 46.1% of Themes and 40.1% of Rhemes, suggesting that actions and events play a central role in both initiating and elaborating the

message of the proverbs. Intensive Attributive processes are especially prominent in the Rheme (31.1%) but almost absent from the Theme (2.5%), indicating that qualities and attributes are often part of the information being developed rather than introduced. Existential processes show a marked presence in the Theme (20.5%) compared to a much lower frequency in the Rheme (3.9%), suggesting that they are primarily used to set up a situational context. Mental, verbal, and possessive attributive processes are relatively low in frequency, with each type comprising between 3% and 7% of the Rheme and less than 6% of the Theme. Behavioural processes are more common in the Theme (12.8%) but almost absent from the Rheme (0.2%). Other process types such as Circumstantial Attributive, Circumstantial Identifying, and Possessive Identifying occur only in the Rheme and at very low rates, indicating their marginal role. Overall, material and attributive processes dominate, shaping both the structure and message of the proverbs.

In conclusion, the correlation between process types in the Theme and Rheme across English, Persian, and Spanish proverbs reflects the distinct linguistic and cultural priorities of each language. While material processes dominate in the Theme in English and Spanish corpora, the prominence of relational processes in the Rheme, particularly relational intensive attributive processes, indicates a shared tendency to focus on the attributes or qualities of subjects in the expression of proverbial wisdom. These findings underscore the role of cultural and linguistic context in shaping how meaning is constructed and communicated in proverbs.

4.2 Discussion of the Distribution of Participant Types in Theme and Rheme

The analysis also shows both similarities and differences in the participant types in the Theme and the Rheme in the three corpora. In the Theme position, the most frequent participant types across the three corpora were Carrier and Actor. In English (45.6%) and Persian (39.5%), the Carrier predominated, indicating the importance of introducing a subject or concept at the beginning of the proverb. In contrast, Spanish placed greater emphasis on the Actor (37.5%), highlighting actions or processes as the starting point. The second most frequent participant in English and Persian was the Actor, while in Spanish, the Carrier took second place. The third most frequent participants varied by language: in English, the Identified participant (6.5%) suggested a focus on identifying concepts, in Persian, the Goal (13.6%) emphasized the recipient of actions, and in Spanish, the Attribute (9.9%) highlighted qualities or characteristics. The fourth most frequent participants also differed: Goal (6.0%) in English, Identified (5.8%) in Persian, and Recipient (5.2%) in Spanish, further reflecting language-specific variations in thematic focus.

The outcome of this study is therefore comparable with McCabe's (1999) in that Carrier is the most frequent participant in the Theme in both the Spanish (17%) and English (21%) corpora examined in her study. However, there is a discrepancy concerning another dominant participant in her study (Identified, 5% and 6% in English and Spanish, respectively), which is not among the most dominant participants in this study and occupies fourth place in the English (6.5%) and Persian (5.8%) corpora and sixth place in the Spanish corpus in this study.

The analysis of the Rheme in the three corpora revealed differences in the frequency of participants across languages. The Attribute was the most frequent participant overall, with the highest frequency in English (46.0%), followed by Persian (43.1%) and Spanish (25.4%), highlighting the importance of explaining qualities in proverbs. The Goal also appeared prominently, with similar frequencies across English (18.5%), Persian (18.6%), and Spanish (16.1%), emphasizing the object or result of actions. The third most frequent participant varied: in English, it was the Existent (7.5%), focusing on existence, while in Persian and Spanish, it was the Actor (7.8% and 14.3%, respectively), emphasizing action and agency. English and Persian shared the Identifier as the fourth most frequent participant (7.0% and 6.4%, respectively), reflecting a focus on identification, while in Spanish, the Carrier (11.6%) was fourth, indicating a greater emphasis on the subject or concept being discussed.

A similarity between this study's findings and McCabe's is that the most frequently encountered participants in the Rheme are Attribute (30% in English and 32% in Spanish) and Goal (14% in English and 8% in Spanish); however, the third most frequent participants in the Rheme in this study are Actor and Existent, which do not appear among the most popular participants in McCabe's study.

In conclusion, the correlation between participant types in the Theme and Rheme across English, Persian, and Spanish proverbs reveals both common patterns and language-specific preferences. The Carrier and Actor are significant in the Theme across all languages, while the prominence of participants like Goal, Attribute, and Identified highlights how each language prioritizes different meanings. In Rheme, the Attribute and Goal are dominant participants across the three languages, with subtle differences in the third and fourth most frequent participants indicating variations in how actions, qualities, and existence are conveyed in proverbs. These findings emphasize the impact of linguistic and cultural factors on the structure and interpretation of proverbs.

4.3 Discussion of the Distribution of Circumstance Types in the Theme and Rheme

The results of the analysis also demonstrate a shared preference for certain circumstance types, particularly in the location, but also highlight distinct tendencies in the remaining circumstances, reflecting cultural and linguistic variations. Location emerged as the most frequent circumstance type in both the Theme and the Rheme in all three corpora, with Persian (34.2%, N = 24) and Spanish (43.2%, N = 32) showing a higher frequency than English (59.2%, N = 16) in the Theme, and Persian (54.8%, N = 51) surpassing English (42.5%, N = 37) and Spanish (43.4%, N = 33) in the Rheme. This suggests that all three languages prioritize the establishment of a setting or context in both the Theme and the Rheme, which is consistent with the nature of proverbs as statements of general truth or wisdom often linked to specific places or situations.

The second most frequent circumstance types in the Theme differed across the corpora: contingency (22.2%) in English, cause (22.8%) in Persian, and cause (25.6%) in Spanish. This reflects varying linguistic preferences in how the circumstance is framed in the initial part of the proverb. In English, contingency is prominently used, indicating a dependency on which something is done or achieved. In contrast, Persian and Spanish proverbs highlight the reason or cause behind an action. This variation suggests a cultural difference in how proverbs conceptualize the nature of the events they describe. In the case of the third most frequent circumstance, Persian and Spanish share contingency (20% and 9.4%, respectively), while English uses manner (14.8%). This divergence further illustrates the distinct thematic emphases in the three languages, with Persian and Spanish incorporating conditional relationships more frequently, while English emphasizes the manner in which events unfold.

Regarding the Rheme, after location, manner was the second most frequent circumstance type in English and Persian corpora (18.3% in English and 15% in Persian), indicating a shared linguistic strategy of elaborating on the manner in which actions or events are carried out. The second place in the Spanish corpus is taken by extent (14.4%) indicating the degree, scope, or range of a situation or condition. However, the third most frequent circumstance varied across languages: matter in English (14.9%), extent in Persian (8.6%), and manner (13.1%) in Spanish. This further emphasizes the linguistic and cultural variation in how proverbs express and elaborate on the circumstances of actions or events. In terms of the remaining circumstance types, English shows a relatively limited variety, with only four types appearing in the Theme – location, contingency, manner, and cause – reflecting a simpler thematic structure compared to the other languages. Persian and Spanish, however, exhibit a broader range of circumstances in both the Theme and the Rheme, particularly with the inclusion of types such as extent and accompaniment, which further distinguishes them from English.

These findings broadly support McCabe's (1992) work in terms of location as the most frequent circumstance in the Theme in its English (12%) and Spanish (13%) corpora. The order of dominance of circumstance types in McCabe's study does not show a similar trend for both English and Spanish in that location, manner (4% and 4.5%), extent (3% and 2%), and cause (1.5% and 1.9%) are the most frequent types encountered in the Theme in her corpora (English and Spanish, respectively), while in this study every corpus followed a distinct trend. The fact that location occurs as the most frequent circumstance in the Theme in all three corpora in this research shows that proverbs tend to thematize the time and space of their message. The only compatibility between the findings of this study with those of McCabe's study is that location and manner are the top two circumstance types in the Rheme only for the English corpus of this study, although manner (15% and 19% in English and Spanish, respectively) precedes location (16.5% and 16% in English and Spanish, respectively) in the Spanish corpus in her study.

In summary, the correlation between circumstance types in the Theme and the Rheme reveals both cross-linguistic similarities and unique features in the proverbs of each language. While all three corpora emphasize location as the primary circumstance type, the variation in the second and third most frequent types highlights differences in how proverbs conceptualize and express circumstances. English tends to favor a simpler structure in the Theme with fewer types of circumstances, while Persian and Spanish demonstrate a greater diversity of thematic elements, reflecting the unique ways in which each language and culture constructs proverbial wisdom.

Finally, the results of the analysis of process types, participant types, and circumstance types in the Theme and Rheme of proverbs across English, Persian, and Spanish reveal notable patterns that construe H1, which assume that proverbs used in different languages to describe the same experience can use similar structural operations to characterize the functional organization of clausal structure. Firstly, the predominance of material and relational processes suggests that all three languages use similar structural operations to convey ideational meanings, emphasizing actions and relationships in the context of proverbs. These process types are essential for unfolding the information in the text, allowing the speaker to share experience and knowledge with the hearer. Secondly, in terms of participant types, the frequent appearance of Carrier, Attribute, and Actor across the three corpora further supports the hypothesis, as these participants play a significant role in expressing relational and material actions, guiding the listener in understanding the intended message. Thirdly, location, as the most common circumstance type in both the Theme and Rheme, also contributes to contextualizing the action and reinforcing the interpretation of proverbs across languages. Taken together, these findings suggest that despite potential language-specific variations, the structural operations in the Theme of the proverbs demonstrate a shared functional organization, allowing speakers of different languages to convey ideational meaning in a comparable manner. Hence, the use

of process, participant, and circumstance types in the Theme and Rheme aligns with the textual metafunction, supporting the idea that languages share structural tools to express equivalent proverbs. All this evidence is supported by the results of the Chi-Square tests, which revealed a strong correlation among the three languages in terms of how information is organized within their proverbs. Only a few discrepancies were observed, particularly concerning the distribution of process types – especially in the Theme – and circumstance types in the Theme and Rheme.

4.4 Discussion of the Grammatical Properties of the Proverbs

After discussing the results of all quantitative analyses, it is now time to relate the qualitative information derived from those analyses in order to address the broader research question, namely RQ2, and to confirm or reject the corresponding hypotheses, that is H2. This correlation will be undertaken in this and the following section. As discussed above, the study's findings show more similarities than differences in the proverbs in the three languages semantically, albeit less syntactically.

Semantically speaking, and in accordance with the TRANSITIVITY system – which comprises elements such as process, participants, and circumstance – the results derived from the frequency counts in the overall corpora as well as in the Theme and Rheme positions reveal a generally consistent trend across the three languages. However, this similarity appears to be less pronounced with respect to the distribution of process types and circumstance types. Strikingly, in the Theme analysis, each of the three languages showed a completely distinct behaviour in that only two processes of material and behavioural were found in the English corpus, no process at all in the Theme of the Persian corpus, and a variety of processes in the Spanish corpus starting with existential followed by material. To put it in a nutshell, this discrepancy in the Theme of the three corpora stands for the fact that English grammar favors the SVO word order, Persian does the SOV, and Spanish shows more flexibility given the VSO order. On the other hand, the few cases of material processes (events or actions) and behavioural processes (physiological and psychological behaviours) in the English corpus are imperative clauses. A variety of process types in the Theme in the Spanish corpus confirms the flexibility of word order in this language. Some similarity is found between the English and the Spanish corpora in the way that material processes are common to both corpora and are the most dominant in English, and the second most frequent process in Spanish after existential. The high rate enjoyed by the existential process in Spanish is because the structure 'hay que' is used for giving advice, which is in fact the essence of proverbs. The dominance of material clauses in English stands for more clauses with active verbs, while the dominance of existential clauses in the Spanish corpus demonstrates more use of existence and clauses with stative verbs.

However, the process analysis given Rheme only showed similarity between English and Persian where relational and material processes occupy the first and second place, while Spanish corpus included more material process in its Rheme followed by relational one.

The analysis of Theme in terms of participants shows that Persian and English follow a similar trend in that their four most frequent participants are Carrier, Actor, Identified, and Goal, although the ordering of the third and the fourth is reversed in the Persian corpus. This means that English and Persian proverbs tend to thematize an element with an attribute or something that is related to something else (Carrier) more than other participants. In second place, the two corpora thematize a participant that carries out a material action (Actor) followed by another frequent participant that functions like a Carrier, except that Carrier is represented by the attributive clauses, but in this case it is represented in the identifying clauses (Identified). The high percentage of Identified shows that proverbs convey their message through the identification of concepts or things. The high frequency of Goal, which occupies third place in the Persian corpus and the fourth place in the English and appears in transitive clauses, is another reason for the dominance of material processes in English and Persian proverbs. This shows that, since Goal is a participant that appears in transitive clauses, the Persian corpus is slightly ahead of the English in its use of transitive clauses. Concerning the Spanish corpus of the study, the thematized participants (Actor, Carrier, Attribute, Recipient) show that Spanish proverbs thematize the doer of an action (Actor) first and then an element with some attributes (Carrier), which is the reverse order to that of English and Persian proverbs (Carrier and Actor, respectively). Attribute, that is to say a quality ascribed to an entity, occupies third place in the Theme in the Spanish corpus, with the fourth place occupied by Recipient as a participant in a material process, receiving a service. The distinct preference of Spanish proverbs to thematize participants might be due to the flexibility of the Spanish grammar word order, which is pragmatically oriented.

With regard to the analysis of Rheme, the three corpora are similar only in terms of the first two most dominant participants, Attribute and Goal; while the Persian and Spanish corpora are similar in terms of their third most frequent participant, the Actor, and English and Persian in that their fourth is Identifier. The dominance of Attribute and Goal in the Rheme in the three languages shows that their proverbs tend to put description (Attribute) and the element that is affected by a process (Goal) in the Rheme of the clause.

The findings regarding circumstance types in the Theme and Rheme positions suggest a consistent trend for location across the three languages. When location appears as Theme, it underscores the significance of time or place in conveying the wisdom embedded in the proverbs within the three corpora. However, no commonality is observed among the corpora for

the second and third circumstance types. Notably, Persian and Spanish share similarity in the second most frequent circumstance type in the Theme—namely, cause (the reason or motivation behind actions or states). In contrast, English and Persian align in the Rheme, where the second most frequent circumstance type is manner (the way in which actions or states occur).

In summary, more similarities than differences were observed across the proverbs in the three languages. This observation is supported by statistical evidence, as the Chi-Square test results for each of the two systems – TRANSITIVITY and THEME – consistently showed Chi-Square values (χ^2) greater than the corresponding critical values (χ^2 tabular). Consequently, the null hypothesis, which posits no significant relationship between the languages and the elements within the TRANSITIVITY and THEME systems, was rejected. This indicates a statistically significant correlation among the languages with regard to the structural and semantic distribution of processes, participants, circumstances in the proverbs analysed. However, there were some cases in which the result of the Chi-Square proved a contrary result meaning that there is no relationship between the languages and the variables, namely the process in Theme, the process in Rheme for English and Persian corpora, the circumstance in Rheme for the three corpora, the circumstance in Rheme for English and Persian, and for Persian and Spanish.

In conclusion, the results of the comparative analysis of English, Persian, and Spanish proverbs point to both shared tendencies and notable divergences, which can be attributed to syntactic and semantic factors inherent to each language. Firstly, the lack of correlation in the frequency of the distribution of the process types within the Theme across the three languages, may be linked to the fact that, although the proverbs are pragmatically equivalent, referring to the same real-world situations or general truths, they are not always semantically identical. This means that while a proverb in one language might convey the same moral lesson or universal wisdom as its counterpart in another, it may do so through different kinds of events or actions, realized through distinct process types. Moreover, although the selection of a particular process type entails a corresponding set of participant types, the relative frequencies and distributions of these participants appear to be more stable across languages. In contrast, circumstance types, which are not semantically required by the process type, tend to vary more. This flexibility allows each language to add different types of circumstantial elements depending on how much contextual or secondary information it chooses to convey.

Finally, the observed correlation in the use of TRANSITIVITY elements in the Theme across the three languages suggests a varied approach to structuring information at the clause level, which is likely due to specific syntactic properties of each language. These differences are therefore shaped by both constraints derived from a canonical word order – Persian

generally displays verb-final constructions, English tends to use SVO sentences, and word order in Spanish is relatively flexible although it is generally considered to be SVO – and how each language organizes information structure – such as topicalization strategies or subject-prominence – and reflect deeper typological characteristics that influence the grammatical realization of discourse functions.

5 Conclusion

This research analysed equivalent proverbs in English, Persian, and Spanish through Halliday's Systemic Functional Grammar. The comparative study shows both linguistic and cultural similarities and differences across the three languages. While the functions of proverbs are largely shared, variations in frequency, structure, and emphasis highlight subtle distinctions that reflect different worldviews.

For instance, the English and Persian corpora exhibit similarities in emphasising relational and material processes, often focusing on states and descriptions rather than actions. This suggests a preference for stability and explanation. By contrast, Spanish proverbs highlight dynamic and action-oriented material processes in both the Theme and Rheme, reflecting a sociocultural inclination towards practicality and directness. Spanish proverbs often provide clear, actionable advice.

Furthermore, participant roles in the Theme also reveal cultural differences. In the Spanish corpus, proverbs tend to focus more on the Actor as the central participant, suggesting a cultural emphasis on individual agency and action. In English and Persian proverbs, however, the Carrier (the entity to which an attribute is assigned) is more commonly thematized, indicating a more static approach where entities are described rather than depicted as active agents. This difference could point to cultural values that prioritize personal responsibility and action, as in Spanish, versus a more reflective or descriptive view of the world, as seen in English and Persian proverbs.

In terms of circumstance, all three languages exhibit a common focus on location, which may reflect the universal importance of situating knowledge within a spatial or temporal context. However, the order of dominance among other circumstances – such as cause, manner, matter – differs across the languages, revealing divergent cultural priorities. For instance, English may feature more instances of manner circumstances due to a cultural focus on how things happen or the

way the actions are done. Persian and Spanish, by contrast, appears to emphasize the cause, which could suggest a cultural tendency to seek explanations for actions or events.

Ultimately, while the analysis of the proverbs in English, Persian, and Spanish reveals significant similarities, the differences in the frequency of processes, participants, and circumstances in the Themes and Rhemes in proverbs highlight important linguistic differences. These differences suggest that the proverbs not only serve as a linguistic tool but also as a reflection of the values, priorities, and worldviews of each culture, confirming the hypothesis that equivalent proverbs share certain properties semantically and syntactically. In conclusion, the analysis demonstrates that, while there are notable linguistic similarities among the proverbs in these three languages, the observed differences offer insights into the cultural characteristics unique to each. Thus, the study suggests that language, while universally functional, remains deeply embedded in the cultural contexts from which it emerges.

Data availability The dataset for this study is presented in the three appendices A, B and C and it is available at [10.6084/m9.figshare.30244594](https://doi.org/10.6084/m9.figshare.30244594)

References

- Akabuike, G. L. (2020). Transitivity in proverbs in Achebe's things fall apart. *AJELLS: Awka Journal of English Language and Literary Studies*, 7(1), 208–232.
- Apperson, G. L. (1993). *The Wordsworth Dictionary of Proverbs*. Ware, Hertfordshire: Wordsworth Editions.
- Comrie, B. (1989). *Language Universals and Linguistic Typology: Syntax and Morphology* (2nd. Ed.). Chicago: Chicago University Press.
- Correas, G. (1924). *Vocabulario de Refranes y Frases Proverbiales*. Madrid: Olózaga.
- Dabbagh, A., & Noshadi, M. (2015). An interpretation of the significance of 'time': The case of English and Persian proverbs. *Theory and Practice in Language Studies*, 5(12), 2581–2590.
- Dabir-Moghaddam, M. (2018). Typological approaches and dialects. In A. Sedighi, & P. Shabani-Jadidi (Eds.), *The Oxford Handbook of Persian Linguistics*, (pp. 52-88). Oxford: Oxford Academic.

- Dehkhoda, A. A. (1984). *Amsaal-o-Hekam*. Tehran: Sepehr.
- Eggins, S. (2004). *An Introduction to Systemic Functional Linguistics* (2nd. Ed.). London & New York: Continuum.
- Emodi, N. L. (2021). Transitivity analysis of proverbs in Achebe's a man of the people. *International Journal of English Linguistics*, 11(5), 77–90.
- Emodi, N. L., & Azuka, O. F. (2022). Transitivity of proverbs in things fall apart. *International Journal of English Language Studies*, 4(2), 44–55.
- Greenberg, J. H. (1963). Some universals of grammar with particular reference to the order of meaningful elements. In J. H. Greenberg (Ed.), *Universals of Language* (pp. 40–70). Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.
- Hableroudi, M. A. (1965). *Majma ol Amsaal* (4th. Ed.). Tehran: Department of Popular Culture.
- Halliday, M. A. K. (1967). Grammar, Society and the Noun. *Lecture in 1966 at University College London*.
- Halliday, M. A. K. (1968). Notes on transitivity and theme in English, part 3, *Journal of Linguistics*, 4(2), 179–215.
- Halliday, M. A. K. (1975). *Leaming How to Mean*. London: Edward Arnold.
- Halliday, M. A. K. (1978). *Language as Social Semiotic: The Social Interpretation of Language and Meaning*. London: Edward Arnold.
- Halliday, M. A. K. (1985). *An Introduction to Functional Grammar* (1st. ed.). London: Edward Arnold.
- Halliday, M. A. K. (1994). Language and the theory of codes. In A. R. Sadovnik (Ed.), *Knowledge and Pedagogy: The Sociology of Basil Bernstein* (pp. 124–142). Norwood: Ablex.
- Halliday, M. A. K., & Hasan, R. (1976). *Cohesion in English*. London: Longman.
- Halliday, M. A. K., & Matthiessen, C. M. I. M. (2004). *An Introduction to Functional Grammar* (3rd. Ed.). London: Edward Arnold.
- Halliday, M. A. K., & Matthiessen, C. M. I. M. (2014). *Halliday's Introduction to Functional Grammar* (4th. Ed.). Oxon: Routledge.
- Hasan, R. (1984). The nursery tale as a genre. *Nottingham Linguistic Circular*, 13, 51–72.

- Hasan, R. (1985). Lending and borrowing: from grammar to lexis. *Beitrage zur Phonetik und Linguistik*, 48, 56–67.
- Hunt, K. W. (1977). Early blooming and late blooming syntactic structures. In C. R. Cooper, & L. Odell (Eds.), *Procedures for Evaluating Writing: Assumptions and Needed Research*, 42(1), 91–104. Chicago (IL): National Council of Teachers of English.
- Martin, R. J. (1992). *English Text: System and Structure*. Amsterdam: John Benjamins.
- Matthiessen, C. M. I. M. (1995). *Lexicogrammatical Cartography: English Systems*. Tokyo: International Language Sciences Publishers.
- Matthiessen, C. M. I. M. (2009). Ideas and new directions. In M. A. K. Halliday, & J. J. Webster (Eds.), *A companion to systemic functional linguistics* (pp. 12–58). London & New York: Continuum.
- McCabe, A. M. (1999). *Theme and Thematic Patterns in Spanish and English History Texts* (Doctoral Dissertation, Aston University of England).
- Mieder, W. (2021). *Dictionary of Authentic American Proverbs*. Oxford: Oxford University Press
- Mieder W, Kingsbury, S. A., & Harder K. B. (1992). *A Dictionary of American Proverbs*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Mohamadi, M., & Nabifar, N. (2012). A comparative study of English and Persian proverbs based on Halliday's experiential metafunction. *Journal of Academic and Applied Studies*, 2(8), 22–36.
- Rodríguez Arancón, P. (2013). The use of SFL genre theory for the analysis of students' writing skills in ESP. *Revista Española de Lingüística aplicada* (pp. 245-262).
- Sbarbi y Osuna, J. M. (1922). *Diccionario De Refranes, Adagios, Refranes, Modismos, Locuciones Y Frases Proverbiales De La Lengua Española*. Madrid: Librería de Los Sucesores de Hernando.
- Sevilla Muñoz, J., & Zurdó Ruiz de Ayúcar, M. T. (2009). *Refranero multilingüe*. Madrid: Instituto Cervantes (Centro Virtual Cervantes). CVC. Refranero Multilingüe.
- Shahri, J. (2021). *Qand o Namak*. Tehran: Moin.
- Simpson, J., & Speake, J. (2002). *The Concise Oxford Dictionary of Proverbs* (5th. Ed.). Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Speake, J. (2008). *The Oxford Dictionary of Proverbs*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

Whiting, B. J. (1977). *Early American Proverbs and Proverbial Phrases*. Cambridge (MA): Belknap Press of Harvard University Press.

Zou Alfaghari, H. (2009). *Farhange Bozorge Zarbolmasalhaye Farsi*. Tehran: Moin.